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THE RISING NEPAL

ALL BE HAPPY, ALL BE WELL



PHOTO: THE OFFICE OF PRESIDENT

President Ramchandra Paudel receiving the report of the National Assembly election 2024 presented by Chief Election Commissioner Dinesh Kumar Thapaliya at the President's Office, Sheetal Niwas in Kathmandu on Sunday.

NA ELECTION REPORT PRESENTED TO PRESIDENT

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 28

Chief Election Commissioner Dinesh Kumar Thapaliya presented the report of the National Assembly election 2024 to President Ramchandra Paudel on Sunday.

Issuing a press statement on Sunday, Shailaja Regmi Bhattarai, spokesperson for the Office of the President, informed that the report was submitted according to Article 60 of the Election to the Members of the National Assembly Act, 2018.

On the occasion, President Paudel thanked the EC for successfully completing the election in accordance with constitutional provisions. Additionally, he instructed the Election Commission (EC) to be always ready to conduct all-level elections.

Chief Election Commissioner Thapaliya presented the report with details of 19 candidates from five different political parties elected as the National Assembly members.

According to the report, 51 candidates from eight parties had contested the election while a total of 12 parties had registered for the election. Similarly, 1,999 of 2,046 total voters cast their votes.

He said that the EC had always been actively engaged in ensuring the exercise of citizens' rights and controlling the activities which go against the election code of conducts.

Some laws yet to be amended regarding federalism: PM



BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 28

Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' has said that some laws related to the implementation of federalism are yet to be amended and formulated even though the basic structure has been prepared for the execution of the federal governance system.

"Although the people's representatives were elected and completed one term, there was ambiguity in many areas in the absence of legal provisions," he said at the high-level discussion on the draft report on the revision of 'unbundling/detailing of the list of exclusive and concurrent powers' held at Singha Durbar on Sunday.

Mentioning that some laws are yet to be amended and enacted, Prime Minister Prachanda said that during the practice of running the government, the need for detailing and amendment was felt while the provincial and local levels also demanded the changes. "Therefore, the amendment process of the laws was advanced," he said.

According to PM Prachanda, after the promulgation of the constitution, the federal governance system based on the principles of cooperation, coexistence and coordination is being practised.

He said that in the eight years since the promulgation of the constitution, the country has achieved encouraging achievements. The basic structures necessary for the implementation of federalism have been built in a short time.

> In the eight years since the promulgation of the constitution, the country has achieved encouraging achievements. The basic structures necessary for the implementation of federalism have been built in a short time.

In order to remove the duplication and ambiguities seen in the implementation of federalism, the meeting of the National Coordination Council held in June 2023 decided to form revision and recommendation committee on 'unbundling/detailing of the list of exclusive and concurrent powers'.

Arjun Prasad Pokharel, Coordinator of the committee, presented the progress made at the work expansion.

Likewise, Dr. Somlal Subedi, speaking as an expert on the topic, informed about the main theoretical criteria adopted for the unbundling and detailing, and the scope of works of the federal, provincial and local levels. The participants presented their views on the security, governance, law, and socio-economic sectors.

Dr. Subedi presented the solutions related to the unbundling of works among the various levels of the government and said that the federal level should look after the matters related to the nature of regulation, standards and uniformity across the country.

Likewise, development, infrastructure, regional coordination and promotion should be managed by the province, and service delivery by the local level.

Dr. Subedi informed that arrangements should be made to allow provincial or local authorities to exercise their rights in accordance with federal laws.

The detailing of the list of single and common rights of the federation, state and local level mentioned in schedule 5 to 9 of the constitution was approved by the Cabinet in January on 18 January 2016, and is being implemented.

Deputy Prime Ministers, chairmen of the House Panels of the National Assembly and the House of Representatives, lawmakers, leaders of various parties, chief secretary and secretaries of various ministries and experts were present in the discussion.

NRNA HANDS OVER MOBILE BLOOD BUS TO LUMBINI

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 28

The Non-Resident Nepali Association (NRNA) has handed over a mobile blood bus to Lumbini Province.

President of the Association Dr. Badri KC handed over the bus to the President of Nepal Red Cross Society Banke, Govardhan Singh Samjhana through Kalruddin Rai, acting Mayor of Nepalgunj Sub-Metropolitan City at a ceremony held here on Friday.

The mobile blood bus costs about Rs. 7 million. Addressing the programme, Dr. KC said that more than Rs. 50 million Nepalis have been displaced abroad due to various reasons.

Expressing grief over the daily arrival of 10 to 12 dead bodies from abroad to Nepal, he said that the NRNA was working for the welfare of the workers abroad. He informed that in the last two decades, the Association has invested Rs. 100 billion and done charity work worth Rs. 1 billion.

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'Health insurance key to better healthcare'

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 28

Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda,' underscored the necessity of enhancing the effectiveness of health insurance to ensure improved access and utilisation of high-quality health services for all citizens.

PM Prachanda made this remark during the 12th meeting of Patan Institute of Health Sciences in Lalitpur on Sunday.

Emphasizing the commitment to achieving universal health coverage through social health insurance, PM Prachanda commended the positive efforts made by local levels in making the health insurance programme successful. He particularly highlighted the agreement signed with Lalitpur Metropolitan City, aiming to provide health services with experts as a potential model programme for the entire country.

"I believe that the agreement signed with Lalitpur Metropolitan City to provide health services of experts to make the national health insurance programme successful will become a model programme for the country," said PM Prachanda.

Expressing optimism about the future of health services, PM Prachanda asserted that the institution's offerings to the public would become more standardized and agile. He recognized the significant role played by the hospital, especially during the global COVID-19 pandemic, and urged for a focus on international-level studies and research in the health sciences.

The Prime Minister highlighted the need for producing skilled and quality health manpower, directing the institute to move in that direction. He expressed confidence that the institute's services would further improve, expanding access to hospital services for more citizens.

In his address, PM Prachanda conveyed his happiness about attending the twelfth meeting of the Patan Institute of Health Sciences and offered guidance on the institution's policies and decisions. He commended the institution for its contributions to the health sector through the provision of health services, education, and scientific research.

Acknowledging the institution's role in the development and prosperity of Nepal, PM Prachanda stressed that health of the common citizens is vital for the country's progress. He encouraged the institution to continue its exemplary initiatives, providing community-based services beyond its operational area.

PM Prachanda concluded by directing relevant government agencies to prioritize the construction of necessary physical infrastructure, emphasizing the need for accessible and quality education and health services. He urged the institution to improve services, ensuring that citizens in rural areas, who often lag in the human development index, have increased access to quality healthcare.

The government is optimistic that such efforts will contribute to the overall well-being and development of the nation, making quality healthcare accessible to all Nepali citizens.

SC issues directive order to amend NHRC Act

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 28

The Supreme Court has recently published the full text of the directive order issued in September last year in a writ petition filed five years ago regarding the lack of effective implementation of recommendations by the National Human Rights Commission.

In the writ petition, the petitioner had claimed that section 13 (3) of Investigation of Enforced Disappearances Persons, Truth and Reconciliation Commission Act, 2014 is inconsistent with the constitutional provision providing the functions and powers of the National Human Rights Commission viz. Art. 249 of the Constitution of Nepal, accordingly, the Commission should have jurisdiction to investigate the cases of human rights violations during armed conflict.

Furthermore, the petitioner claimed that the name of Human Rights violators be made public, the Commission's recommendations be implemented effectively, human rights violators be restricted from recommendation, appointment, promotion or any career development in any constitutional or public post and the human rights violators be directly prosecuted by Attorney General as per the recommendation of the Commission.

Part of the petitioner's claim included providing the Commission authority to punish for contempt those officials, persons or agencies that do not implement or observe the recommendations or orders or directives made by the Commission about violations of human rights.

The writ petition was dismissed by the Court on the ground of positive assurance made by the defendant regarding the claims through their written response and initiation of the amendment process of the National Human Rights Commission Act.

However, the Court issued the directive order providing the significant basis for the empowerment and reform of the Commission. The directive order inter alia includes the order to expedite the amendment process of the National Human Rights Commission Act as per Commission's recommendation, prosecute as per the recommendation of the Commission, publish names of Human Rights violators, restricting

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Leprosy threat continues in Nepal

BY PALLAV BHUSAL
Kathmandu, Jan. 28

Leprosy continues to pose challenges in Nepal despite it being declared not a public health problem in 2010. Fourteen years after the declaration, the battle against the disease is still far from conclusion.

The recently concluded fiscal year 2022/23 saw Nepal reporting 2,522 new leprosy cases, according to data from the Epidemiology and Disease Control Division of the Department of Health Services (EDCD).

Dr. Prashanna Napit, Section Chief in the Leprosy Control and Disability Management Section of EDCD, revealed that currently, 2,510 leprosy patients are receiving treatment. Among them, 1,049 are women, and 181 are children under 14 years old. The new patients include 189 disabled, eight of them children.

Dr. Napit highlighted a concentration of leprosy cases in the districts of Madhes and Lumbini Province and informed that one in every 10,000 people is infected with leprosy. Additionally, he noted the presence of leprosy patients in 14 districts across Nepal.



PHOTO: THE LEPROSY MISSION

Nepal did achieve a milestone of no longer considering leprosy a public health problem in 2010, hence the nation has now aimed for an even more ambitious target which is the complete eradication of leprosy by the year 2030.

Napit highlighted the persistent challenges in eliminating leprosy. He pointed out that the difficulty lies in the elusive nature of the disease, making it challenging for health workers to detect, compounded by the problem of patients concealing their condition.

"Leprosy is caused by the bacterium Mycobacterium leprae, and has a lengthy incubation period. Typically, it takes about three to five years for symptoms to manifest, but in some cases, the onset can be much later, extending up to two decades or more.

This prolonged incubation period poses a challenge for health providers in determining the time and place of infection. Individuals may not be aware of their exposure to the bacteria, and the slow progression of the disease complicates the accurate tracing of the source of infection," said Napit.

He underscored the critical role of early diagnosis and treatment. Swift action during the initial stages not only halts the spread of the disease to others but also significantly reduces the risk of long-term disabilities.

Napit informed that there is no vaccine available against leprosy, but recently there are medicines which can help in curing the disease. Leprosy is treated with multi-drug therapy, an approach that combines different types of antibiotics.

Despite progress, recovered leprosy patients continued to complain about enduring societal stigmatisation. They argued that Nepalese law, particularly Section 71 of the Civil Code 2074, perpetuates discrimination against leprosy survivors. This section prohibits marrying a person with leprosy and allows annulment of such marriages.

Leprosy is not highly contagious, and transmission usually requires prolonged and close contact with an untreated individual with leprosy. Early diagnosis and treatment are vital for managing leprosy and preventing complications, highlighting the importance of healthcare providers' vigilance, particularly in regions where leprosy is endemic.

Additionally, efforts to reduce the stigma associated with leprosy can encourage individuals to seek medical attention sooner, facilitating prompt diagnosis and treatment.

NEPSE posts double-digit gain, turnover stands at Rs. 3.83 billion

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 28



The benchmark of the stock market, NEPSE, has posted a double-digit growth on Sunday, the third transaction day of the week. The index increased by 10.37 points to close at 2,094.46 points on Sunday. The NEPSE, which had been continuously falling for the last seven trading days, has increased today.

The index had declined by 91 points on seven trading days since January 17. The sensitive index which measures the performance of group 'A' companies increased by 0.73 points to close at 380.20 points. A total of 10,751,164 shares worth Rs. 3.83 billion of 306 companies were sold in 100,782 transactions today.

The sub-indices of all groups, except banking, hotels and tourism and manufacturing and processing increased in today's transaction. Sub-index of the non-life insurance group saw the highest growth of 57.01 points followed by the life insurance and development bank group whose indices increased by 53.94 points and 49.34 points respectively.

Similarly, hydropower sub-index increased by 34.50 points, others by 22.81 points, finance by 14.71 points and microfinance by 20.98 points. Sub-index of trading group increased by 5.43 points and investment by 0.73 points.

However, the sub-index of hotels and tourism decreased by 104.31 points, banking by 1.09 points and manufacturing and processing by 28.54 points. Share price of two companies, including Mid-Solu Hydropower and Mathillo Mailun Khola Jalvidhyut have increased by 10 per cent.

Similarly, the share price of Samling Power Company increased by 9.98 per cent, Hathway Investment Nepal by 8.73 per cent and Mountain Hydro Nepal by 7.97 per cent. However, share price of Chandragiri Hills decreased by 9.86 per cent, Infinity Laghubitta Bittiya Sanstha by 6.40 per cent and Manakamana Smart Laghubitta Bittiya Sanstha by 5.19 per cent.

4th Hydro Expo in April

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 28

The IPPAN has been organising the expo every two years aiming to bring in world-class technology in Nepal for the development of hydropower.

The Independent Power Producers' Association, Nepal (IPPAN) is going to organise the fourth edition of the Himalayan Hydro Expo in April, 2024. According to IPPAN, the expo will be held from April 24 to 26, this year at Bhrikutimandap Exhibition Centre in Kathmandu.

The IPPAN has been organising the expo every two years aiming to bring in world-class technology in Nepal for the development of hydropower. A memorandum of understanding has been signed recently between IPPAN and the Expo and Event Management Company for organising the expo.

The government has prepared an energy development roadmap with a target of generating 28,500 MW of electricity in 12 years and sets a target to consume 13,500 MW of electricity internally and export 10,000 MW to India and 5,000 MW to Bangladesh.

"An agreement has been reached between Nepal and India that Nepal will export 10,000 megawatts of electricity to India in 10 years. In this situation, the expo is going to be organised with the aim of attracting domestic and foreign investment in the hydropower sector," said Ganesh Karki, president of IPPAN.

According to Karki, the aim of the expo organised by IPPAN is to create an investment environment by inviting foreign investors to participate in the investment conference to be organised by the government in April.

There will be an exhibition of machinery tools used in the construction of hydropower projects, banks and financial institutions, insurance companies, cement, rods and other materials in the expo. Along with this, seminars and discussions on hydropower, solar, hydrogen and other topics will also be organised, said the IPPAN.

In the expo, demos will be presented to provide information about various hydropower projects as well as competition between innovative ideas in the energy sector. It is expected that there will be more than 200 stalls in the expo and a turnover of more than Rs. 25 billion.

GERMAN TRAIN DRIVERS TO END STRIKE

AP
Berlin, Jan. 28

Germany's train drivers' union is ending its six-day strike early and is back in talks with the country's national railway operator, German news agency dpa reported Saturday.

The strike by the GDL union on passengers trains, which has brought the country to a near standstill since early Wednesday, will end Monday morning at 2 a.m. (0100 GMT), instead of 6 p.m. (1700 GMT) as originally announced. The freight transport strike will end on Sunday evening at 6 p.m. (1700 GMT).

This week's strike was the fourth one by the union during the current negotiations to push their demands in a rancorous dispute with the country's main railway operator, state-owned Deutsche Bahn, over working hours and pay.

Both parties were back in talks on Saturday already and said there would be no further strikes until March 3, dpa reported.

In addition to pay raises, the union has been calling for working hours to be reduced from 38 to 35 per week without a pay cut, a demand which Deutsche Bahn has so far refused.

Dilapidated road creates problems in orange supply

RSS
Parbat, Jan. 28



Farmers of Jaljala rural muncicpality-1, Banskharka, in Parbat district have been facing problems in transporting orange due to bad condition of road. Although a single village of the rural municipality produce orange worth millions of rupees, it could not be transported to market following the bad condition of road reaching villages. There is a problem to big vehicles to reach villages in lack of upgradation of Baribeni-Bagar-Banskharka road connecting Banskharka.

A local Jagat Bahadur Khatri said, "There is gravel road facility from Baribeni and Milan Chowk to reach Banskharka. But big vehicles cannot reach the orange gardens due to dilapidated condition of road." He further said, "There is a compulsion to supply orange up to Beni-Maldhunga road in small vehicles and shift the products to big vehicles from there to take them to market which takes more time and transport cost."

An entrepreneur of Kalimati, who reached here to buy orange, shared that it would be easier if they could transport oranges in a big container. It would take around one and half hours to cross 10 kilometer road, he added. A detailed project report (DPR) has already been carried out to blacktop the road linking Barabeni of Jaljala rural municipaliy-2 toward no 1, Banskharka but the road has not been upgraded yet after the budget has not been allocated for the same.

Meanwhile, in Rukum West different road sections of Rukum West along Rapti highway are being upgraded. It has become easier in movement of vehicles and people after road upgradation from Musikot municipality-4 Solabang along Rapti highway to Shitalpokhari along Mid-Hilly highway, said a bus driver Rim Bahadur Pun. The road along the road section has been widened and blacktopped.

Pun shared, "Earlier, the road was very narrow and there was risk of accident. Now it has become easier to operate vehicle after road upgradation."

A 10-kilomter road from Jalekharka of Salyan to Jhaktekhola of Tribeni rural municipality of Rukum West, six-kilometer road from Solabang of Musikot municipality-4 to Shitalpokhari of Rukum West and six-kilometer road from Solabang to Raukhet along Rapti highway are being upgraded, according to Chief of Road Division office, Chourjahari, Tejaswi Sharma.

Similarly, construction of 10-kilometer road from Jalekharka of Salyan to Jhaktekhola of Tribeni rural municipality-9 in Rukum West has begun from around two years ago at a cost of Rs 210 billion. The road section has achieved 65 per cent physical progress so far.

Likewise, six-kilometer road from Solabang of Musikot municipality-4 to Raukhet along Rapti highway is being blacktopped. The road section has achieved 70 per cent progress so far. A total of Rs 210 billion was allocated for the road upgradation.

Upgradation work of the six-kilometer road from Shitalpokhari to Solabang is underway at a cost of Rs 60 million. The road section has achieved 50 per cent physical progress so far.

JetBlue warns Spirit Airlines it may terminate $3.8 billion buyout

AP
New York, Jan. 28



JetBlue Airways warned that it may end its bid to acquire low-cost carrier Spirit Airlines as soon as this weekend after a federal judge blocked the deal, sending Spirit shares sharply lower Friday.

Spirit shot back that it finds no reason to terminate the deal and will continue to meet its obligations, "and it expects JetBlue to do the same."

A federal judge sided with the Justice Department and blocked JetBlue's proposed $3.8 billion purchase of Spirit last week. The Justice Department sued to block the merger, saying it would drive up fares by eliminating Spirit, the nation's biggest low-cost airline. Both airlines have filed their intention to appeal with a higher court.

JetBlue said in a regulatory filing Friday it told Spirit that certain conditions of their deal might not be met by the deadline set in the airlines' 2022 agreement. JetBlue said that could lead it to terminate the deal as early as Sunday. Spirit responded hours later with its own filing that disputed JetBlue's position.

"Spirit believes there is no basis for terminating the Merger Agreement," Spirit wrote. "Spirit will continue to abide by all of its obligations under the Merger Agreement, and it expects JetBlue to do the same."

Shares of Spirit Airlines Inc., based in Miramar, Florida, fell 13.4% during Friday's session, while JetBlue Airways Corp. gained 3.6%.

JetBlue, based in New York, had argued that it needed to buy Spirit to grow quickly and better compete against bigger rivals that dominate the U.S. air-travel market. Together, the two carriers would control about 10% of the domestic air-travel market, still smaller than American, Delta, United and Southwest.

Both JetBlue and Spirit have struggled financially and have been slower than some other airlines to recover from the pandemic. Since the start of 2020, JetBlue has lost $2.1 billion, and Spirit has lost $1.7 billion.

Spirit is dealing with rising costs, softer demand for its mix of rock-bottom fares but higher fees, and the sidelining of dozens of its Airbus jets because of problems with the Pratt & Whitney engines. It must figure out how to pay or refinance $1.1 billion in debt due next year.

Spirit tried to merge with Frontier Airlines, another low-cost carrier, in early 2022, but JetBlue won a bidding war to push Frontier aside.

Should the deal fall through because of government opposition, JetBlue could be saddled with a $470 million reverse breakup fee, $70 million for Spirit and $400 million for its share holders.

Greta Thunberg to protest airport's expansion

AP
London, Jan. 28

Thunberg, 21, a Swedish environmental campaigner who inspired a global youth movement against climate change, is expected to appear at a court in London next week to face a public order offense charge. She was arrested in October during a demonstration against a major oil and gas industry conference. Thunberg was among the activists who were charged for seeking to block access to the Energy Intelligence Forum. She denied the charge.

Climate activist Greta Thunberg joined a march in southern England on Saturday to protest the use of private jets and the expansion of an airport. Hundreds of local residents and activists holding banners and placards that read "Ban Private Jets" marched to Farnborough Airport, which mostly serves private aircraft. Some beat drums while others lit pink smoke flares.

The airport, located in Hampshire County about 40 miles (64 kilometers) southwest of London, applied last year to increase its maximum number of flights from 50,000 to 70,000 a year.

Groups working to fight climate change, including the organizer of Saturday's protest, Extinction Rebellion, say private jets are much more polluting than commercial passenger airliners. Flights to and from Farnborough Airport carried an average of 2½ passengers per flight in 2022, the group said.

"It is clear that private jets are incompatible with ensuring present and future living conditions on this planet," Thunberg said in a video that Extinction Rebellion posted on social media.

"We're not going to let this continue. We're not going to let the rich few who are responsible for the majority of aviation emissions get away with sacrificing people and the planet," she added.

Farnborough Airport said that it was an important hub for business and corporate travel, and that it recognized the importance of reducing its environmental impact. "The airport's environmental footprint is a fraction that of a traditional commercial airport, yet it serves as one of the largest employment sites in the region," it said in a statement.

Thunberg, 21, a Swedish environmental campaigner who inspired a global youth movement against climate change, is expected to appear at a court in London next week to face a public order offense charge. She was arrested in October during a demonstration against a major oil and gas industry conference. Thunberg was among the activists who were charged for seeking to block access to the Energy Intelligence Forum. She denied the charge.

Widened roads lead to increased road accidents in Pokhara



PHOTO: SANTOSH SUBEDI/TRN

Roadways in Pokhara city as seen in the picture.

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Kaski, Jan. 28

Although major road sections in Pokhara have been widened including the recently developed Pokhara-Hemza road section, road accidents are on the rise claiming many lives. According to the traffic police record, 22 individuals were killed in road accidents in the last six months of the current fiscal in Kaski.

According to the District Traffic Police Office, Kaski, 43 persons died and 32 individuals sustained serious injuries in a total of 64 road accidents that took place in the fiscal year 2021/22.

Similarly, 55 individuals were killed and 79 others were injured in road accidents in the fiscal year 2022/23. Likewise, in the fiscal year 2023/24, 44 persons died and 123 were injured in a total of 117 road accidents, according to the traffic police office.

The number of road accidents has been increasing every year. Most of the road accidents and fatalities occur from Zero Kilo to Bindhyabasini roadside, said the traffic police office. In the last six months, six individuals got killed along the Zero Kilo to Bindhyabasani road section, said traffic police.

Deputy Superintendent of Police (DSP) and spokesperson for the District Police, Shrawan Kumar B.K. said, "The fatal accidents along the Pokhara-Hemza road section have raised the concern of authorities.

Lately, there have been more accidents in the city areas and the highways." The accident that occurred in Pasryang in the last week of December was caused by there being no light on the footpath.

Shiva Prasad Pathak, Senior Sub-Inspector of Traffic Police said that the accidents are happening more due to driver's carelessness, high speed, dilapidated roads, drinking and driving, etc. Although some roads in Pokhara are wide, the bridges connected to those roads are narrow, which escalates accidents.

Prithvi Chowk, the main road of Pokhara, has a six-lane road and a two-lane bridge.

The Zero Kilo Hemza section of the Pokhara-Baglung highway has six lanes, while the Phirke Bridge has two lanes, but still, deaths resulting from road accidents are on the rise.

New trail being explored to Dhaulagiri Base Camp

BY THAKUR PRASAD ACHARYA
Myagdi, Jan. 28

A team comprising tourism entrepreneurs has embarked on a journey to find out a new footpath leading to the Dhaulagiri base camp through Todke, a tourist spot in Myagdi.

A team from the Trekking Agencies Association of Nepal (TAAN), Gandaki, along with a group of 20 individuals including tourism businessmen, journalists, and porters, has departed from Todke in Myagdi, aiming to reach the Dhaulagiri base camp and identify a new trail to connect Mustang.

The team commenced their journey on Saturday from Raghuganga Rural Municipality-5, Todke.

The trekking team will explore, study, and research the Todke-Dhaulagiri trekking route. Dipendra Bahadur Thapa, Minister of Industry, Tourism, Forest, and Environment of Gandaki Province, bade farewell to the team at Todke, the designated point of departure.

While bidding farewell to the team, Minister Thapa said that the tourist trail to Mustang via the Todke-Dhaulagiri base camp would be beneficial and attractive to tourists. He said that the Gandaki Province government would support the construction of infrastructure and the promotion of the identified footpaths.

On the first day on Saturday, the team reached Thadakhani from Todke via Malikadhuri. Krishna Acharya, first vice president of TAAN Gandaki, informed that the second day would involve traveling from Thadakhani to Kuine, the third day from Kuine to Ghasikhark, the fourth day from Ghasikhark to Sangarthala Kachuwa Cave, the fifth day from Kachuwa Cave to the Dhaulagiri base camp, and the sixth day from the base camp to Kalibarah via Mustang.

Kuman Singh Gurung, Secretary for Industry and Tourism of the Ministry, said that while the government and the private sector would assist in promotion, locals should actively participate in tourism development by showcasing their art and culture. He expressed his belief that the development of the new footpath would significantly contribute to the tourism sector of Gandaki Province.

TAAN's first vice president, Acharya, said that the tourism sector faces risks when existing footpaths encounter challenges, such as those arising from the development of motorways.

He added that the necessity to create new footpaths to mitigate such risks and sustain tourism growth.

HEART CHECKUP CAMP ORGANISED

RSS
Kathmandu, Jan. 28

Renewal Energy Confederation of Nepal (RECoN) organised heart checkup camp and health awareness related programmes here on the occasion of First International Day of Clean Energy.

The RECoN under "RI Sector Health Checkup and Awareness Programme' organised the programme with the collaboration of Nepal Cardiac Centre.

Senior cardiologist Dr Om Murti Anil and his team carried out heart checkup of around 100 people.

On the occasion, Dr Anil explained the participants about the risk of heart diseases and precautions to be adopted to reduce it, asking to give up the trend taking regular medicines as unnecessary burden and adopting alternative measures rather than consulting with health workers.

Sharing the information that risk of heart diseases is increasing in Nepal due to unhealthy lifestyle, unhygienic food, no physical exercise, polluted environment, stress, and lack of interest in health awareness, he suggested adopting awareness.

Dr Anil stressed the need of regular health checkup on time and improvement in lifestyle as risk of health disease on youths in increasing in recent period.

Dr Anil urged the renewable energy entrepreneurs also to pay attention towards the promoting the use of clean energy, as increasing the use of renewable will help reduce health risks.

Confederation president Gunaraj Dhakal shared that the heart check-up programme has been organised on the occasion of the First Clean Energy Day since the clean energy also has a role in reducing and preventing heart diseases.

Office-bearers of Nepal Solar Power Producers Association, Nepal Micro Hydropower Development Institute, Nepal Biogas Promotion Association, the Water and Energy Consultants Association of Nepal, the Rural Technology Producers Association of Nepal, Nepal Solar Energy Association, the Bio-energy Entrepreneurs Association, Nepal and Biogas Sector Partnership Nepal, the professional organisations of the renewable energy sector participated in the programme.

Three, including GB Rai of Suryadarshan Cooperative face diffusion notice

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 28

Interpol has issued a diffusion notice against GB (Gitendra Babu) Rai who is accused of co-operative fraud, seeking international policing in his arrest. The District Police Office, Kaski had previously requested the Police Headquarters to issue the notice related to the fraud case involving Suryadarshan Cooperative.

Upon the initiative, the National Central Bureau (NCB), Kathmandu, of the Interpol Office at the Police Headquarters, requested the Secretary General of Interpol to issue the diffusion notice, according to the Deputy Inspector General and Spokesperson for the Police Headquarters Bhim Prasad Dhakal. DIG Dhakal said that two weeks ago, the Headquarters had initiated the process to issue the notice against him.

The police have also recommended issuing the diffusion notice against Suryadarshan Cooperative's current chairman Than Bahadur Budha Magar, and former chairman, Bhupendra Rai. And upon the request, the Interpol, on Sunday only, has issued the same kind of notice against Budha Magar and Rai.

Once the notice is issued, it will help determine whether Rai is in any of the member countries of Interpol. Following this, steps will be taken to extradite him to Nepal. Rai is believed to be in Malaysia, and if confirmed, extradition proceedings will commence.

On October 8, the Kaski District Court ordered the detention of treasurer Kumar Ramtel, pending trial on charges of misappropriation of funds collected from the cooperative's depositors. In the same case, Vice-chairman Kailash Kumar Darlami, members Shiva Bahadur Gurung, and Bhagishwar Aryal were also arrested and are currently in custody pending trial, as per Kaski police.

Arrest warrants have been issued against 19 individuals, including GB Rai, in connection with the Suryadarshan Cooperative fraud case. Fifteen of these individuals are currently at large. The complaint alleges that officials from Suryadarshan embezzled Rs 1.12 billion of the depositors' money.

Under the Cooperative Act, they could face a fine and imprisonment ranging from 8 to 10 years.

The police report indicates that the GB Rai Group embezzled money from Suryadarshan by creating fake shareholders and various companies.

The police have concluded that the cooperative's directors and officials misappropriated funds by opening fake share member accounts and maintaining no assets in the name of the cooperative or individuals.

Pun sells 1716 books in Birendranagar in four days

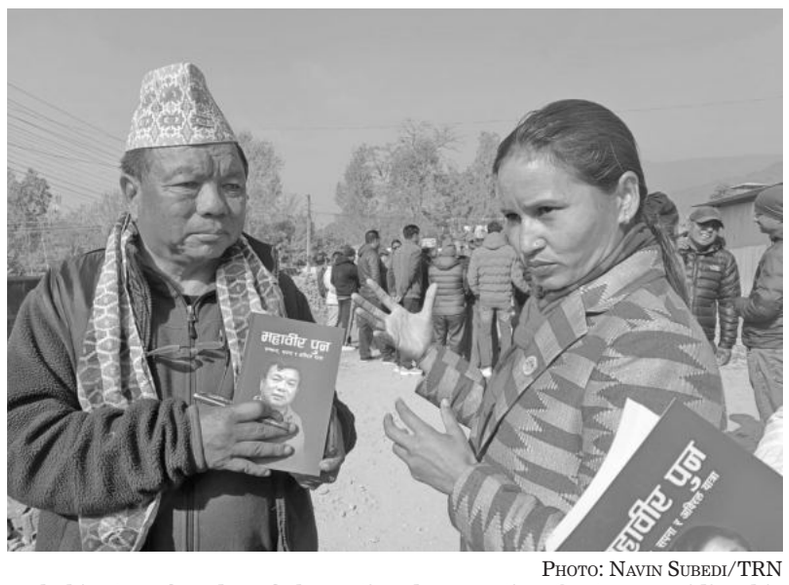


PHOTO: NAVIN SUBEDI/TRN

Mahabir Pun, founder of the National Innovation Centre, providing his book to a customer in Karnali's capital Birendranagar.

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Surkhet, Jan. 28

Mahabir Pun, the founder of the National Innovation Centre, has sold a total of 1,716 copies of his autobiography titled 'Understanding, Dreams and Uninterrupted Journey' in just four days.

Pun who arrived in Karnali's capital Birendranagar four days ago had sold 595 books worth Rs. 446,250 on the first day. On the second day, 350 books were sold for Rs. 262,000.

On the third day, which was also the day of the National Assembly election, Pun visited the place where the election was conducted and sold 421 books for Rs. 315,750. Likewise, on the fourth day, he sold 350 books for Rs. 262,500. Nawaraj Bohara, a social worker from Birendranagar, had assisted Pun in selling his books. The price of his 308-page book is Rs. 750.

Jet boat service makes journey from Bhojpur to Tarai districts easier

RSS
Bhojpur, Jan. 28

The operation of jet boat service in the Arun River has made travel to the Tarai districts easier for the people of the southern parts of Bhojpur district.

Travelling by road to various Tarai districts from Bhojpur was difficult before this due to the lack of bridges over big rivers like Arun and Dudhkoshi. But this problem has been addressed after daily jet boat service came into operation from Kopche of Hatuwagadhi-9, except during the monsoon period.

Indra Thapa, a local, said people can now travel to places like Dharan, Itahari, Biratnagar and other places and return to their homes by jet boat. According to him, operation of a jet boat has made travel easier. When there was no jet boat transport available, people had to walk on the route through cliff for three to four hours to reach Chatara. Thapa said the 19 kilometres distance up to Chatara is covered in 20 to 25 minutes by jet boat travel.



PHOTO: RSS

Jet boat service on the Arun River has made travel easier to some districts for the people in southern parts of Bhojpur district. Traveling by road to various districts from here was difficult before this.

"The operation of jet boat transport service has made travel much easier for the locals at present. Travel by road is difficult during the monsoon as there are no bridges over the major rivers. However, one can travel to the Tarai towns and return home in a day these days with the operation of jet boat services," he said. The locals have to pay Rs. 600 for the 19-kilometres jet boat travel. Another local, Lal Bahadur Pradhan, said the operation of a jet boat in the Arun River here has made it easy also for taking the patients to hospitals as they can be taken to hospital fast.

Stating that it is only two kilometres to reach Tarai via Bhojpur headquarters, Leguwa, Hile and Dhankuta, Pradhan shared the operation of jet boat has shortened the travel time. It has directly benefited locals of southern areas, he added. According to the rural municipality, the operation of a jet boat has connected Bhojpur, Dhankuta and Sunsari with east Tarai.

Chairperson of the rural municipality, Prem Kumar Rai, mentioned that the municipality has been carrying out activities for the development of tourism infrastructures with a target of linking rafting with tourism. With the operation of the jet boat, the distance from Hatuwagadi to Tarai district has become very short which helps contribute in the development of the district. With this, activities are underway to develop tourist sites within the rural municipality incorporating the lowest land of Bhojpur district, Maibeni.

THOUGHT FOR TODAY

Music is the shorthand of emotion.
- Leo Tolstoy

EDITORIAL

Woes Of Susta Locals

Every state has an obligation to protect its citizens. This entails physical, social, legal and economic security of the people. The state is a guardian of the people. Its protection creates an enabling conditions for peace, justice and development, which constitute vital elements in ensuring a life of dignity, prosperity and happiness. The people have a sense of confidence and ownership of the governance system if it safeguards them against impending trouble and crisis that threaten their well-being, livelihood and basic human rights. Failure to guarantee their fundamental rights give rise to despair and disorder in the community. First and foremost, people should be granted citizenship that establishes legal bond between them and the state services. The citizenship certificate is the membership of the state, denoting which state s/he belongs to. Upon taking citizenship, s/he commits to constitution that underlines the rights and responsibilities of the citizens. It bolsters their allegiance to the state.

Rights that citizenship certificate ensures are not merely confined to rights to vote and hold public offices. They include legal rights to get health and education services, social security, employment, land and residency, among others. According to news report carried by this daily, a large number of local residents of Susta in Western Nawalparasi district have been deprived of citizenship. Around 3,133 people of 265 households live in Susta but only 295 individuals have obtained citizenship. Locals said around 1,600 people are eligible for citizenship. They have demanded the citizenship be provided through different process. In the absence of citizenships, the locals have been facing multiple problems. They could not buy SIM card and use mobile phone, work in Nepal or India, open bank accounts and get driving license.

Susta people's woes do not end here. The lack of citizenships has robbed them of the land ownership certificates. This is an irony that Susta people, who have been defending borderland against the encroachment by the southern neighbour for decades, have been denied their legal rights to receive citizenship papers. Susta spans over 40,980 hectares of land. Of this, Indian side has reportedly encroached 14,500 hectares. According to the Armed Police Force, Nepal border outpost (BOP) in Susta, around 19,980 hectares of land has been marked as disputed area. The locals have been using only 7,000 hectares. Of them, only 556 bighas of land are registered in the name of the local people. In 1977, the floods in Narayani River displaced a Village Panchayat comprising nine wards. As the changed river course separated the land, this gave an excuse for the southern side to encroach the Nepali land.

In process of protesting against the infringement, the Susta locals say that they are being harassed and threatened by the Indian security forces on a daily basis. The locals launched the Save Susta Campaign to draw the attention of the government with regard to the solution to the chronic border dispute. They have grown impatient as there is a delay in addressing their issues. Now they are mulling to knock on the door of the court if the government does not solve the dispute. They are now consulting the concerned stakeholders as to how the border issue should be dealt with. The dispute in the border area keeps on dragging while the locals continue to fight for their ancestral land. Susta people's call for justice is valid and the Nepal government should initiate diplomatic efforts to solve the border issue, and take administrative process to grant citizenships to them.

Internet Gaming Disorder

PALLAV BHUSAL

In the fast-evolving age of digital platforms, online gaming has advanced from a normal hobby to a global phenomenon, captivating people from all around the world. While gaming offers a relaxing and entertaining experience, there are many challenges posed by the rising concern of Internet Gaming Disorder (IGD) that demand our consideration. As the virtual world gets more realistic, it is important to address the impact of excessive gaming and its effect on individuals and society.

The World Health Organisation has recognised IGD as a mental health condition that is characterised by impaired control over gaming. Increasing priority given to gaming over other activities, and continuation or escalation of gaming despite negative consequences are challenges of today's world. Not every individual who loves gaming is at risk of developing a disorder. However, those who develop the disorder can face severe consequences including affecting mental health, academic and occupational routine, and personal relationships.

The leading challenge associated with IGD is its potential to worsen the mental health of individuals. People get involved in excessive gaming as a diversion to use virtual worlds as a refuge from real-life stress. While gaming may offer temporary relief, it can inadvertently contribute to a cycle of isolation and exacerbate underlying mental health conditions, such as anxiety and depression. Recognising the interconnected nature of mental health and gaming is crucial for devising effective intervention strategies.

The impact of IGD is not only on individuals but extends to societal levels. The rise in online gaming and its global competition, although providing lucrative opportunities for professional games, has also exaggerated its competitive nature. This hyper-competitive situation may increase a culture of excessive gaming, leading to individuals prioritising gaming achievements over personal well-being. Striking a balance between the pursuit of gaming excellence and maintaining a healthy lifestyle is a challenge that requires the collaboration of industry stakeholders, healthcare professionals, and educators.

Educational institutions should also take up the responsibility of teaching the negative impacts of internet gaming. Educators must teach individuals that gaming should be taken as a legitimate form of entertainment and identify when it becomes a hindrance to academic performance. Therefore, there should also be educational programmes on responsible gaming habits and the potential consequences of excessive gaming, which can empower students to make informed choices about their online activities.

Guardians, too, play a crucial role in mitigating the risk associated with IGD. They should acknowledge their children's gaming habits, establish open lines of communication, set reasonable time limits, and foster a healthy balance between screen time and other activities. Getting involved and gaming together with children at an early age can help guardians guide their children to responsible gaming habits.

In conclusion, the challenges posed by Internet Gaming Disorder in modern society require a complex approach. Mental health professionals, educators, guardians, and the gaming industry must collaborate to create an environment where gaming is enjoyed responsibly. By fostering awareness, providing resources for regulation, and encouraging social interactions, we can maintain the balance between the online and real worlds. Every individual who games actively online, professionally or generally, must ensure that gaming is an enriching aspect of our lives rather than a controlling aspect.

Unexpected Challenges For Israel



P Kharel

TIDE OF TIMES

In a classic case of not forgetting the hardships and indignities the black people in South Africa suffered during the apartheid rule by a white minority, South Africa in the other week moved the International Court of Justice to call for a cease fire to the ongoing "genocide" in Gaza. Later, Uganda supported the South African initiative. In its verdict on Friday, the Hague-based ICC directed Israel to prevent acts of genocide. The ruling is a big setback for Tel Aviv and also an indirect rap against foreign supporters of the Benjamin Netanyahu government.

While more than 25,000 Palestinians have lost their lives, no less than two million others have been forced out of their homes in the territory in 2023. International agencies report that more than 8,000 children have been killed since October, which presents a highly grim picture amidst anger also against Israel's key allies and donors. As the single-largest recipient of the US annual aid, Israel receives $3.5 billion in military aid. The Jewish state with a population of about 9.2 million receives another $1 billion in philanthropic assistance.

The colour of skin demarcated an individual's social station, economic opportunities and justice during apartheid in South Africa. Segregation was the order of the regime, to which the ruling class's cousins in the West were complicit. In fact, Ireland's parliament in May 2021 condemned the "de facto annexation" of Palestinian land with a population of 5.4 million. Its Foreign Minister Jean-Yves Le Drian proudly pointed out that his country was the first among the European Union's 27 member nations to employ the phrase on Israel.

That Israeli government has settled 450,000 Israelis in Palestinian territories occupied for 55 years carries significant demographic implications and, with it, political consequences —something Tel Aviv cannot be unaware of. The future can no longer assure Israel that Palestine's probable prospects of attracting greater proactive substantive support from not only Muslim but also non-Muslim world. Bahrain, Bangladesh, Bolivia, Bulgaria, Chad, Chile, Jordan, Honduras, South Africa and Turkey recalled their ambassadors accredited to Israel, with some of them cutting off all diplomatic ties. This was in protest against the collective punishment after the Hamas's deadly attacks in October.

Table can turn

In "Africa United: How Football Unites", Steve Bloomfield themes a popular sporting discipline to portray and analyse a continent that for long remained colonised, economically exploited and ruthlessly suppressed. Issues can indeed unite communities and countries. It does not bode well for Israel that latest research surveys indicate anti-semitism to have hiked by 388 per cent in the United States and 689 per cent in the United Kingdom.

Sections of the American press have called for their government to be consistent in responding to conflicts in various parts of the world. They pointed out that, if Washington supports illegal annexation of Palestinian territories by Israel, it became the only state to recognise Morocco's sovereignty of Western Sahara. Former US Secretary of State James Baker III described the move as an "astounding retreat from the principles of international law". Weeks before Russian troops entered Ukraine, the US and its allies warned Russia's President Vladimir Putin: "Any use of force to change borders is strictly prohibited under international law." When Russian parliament recognised the independence of two self-declared republics, American Secretary of State Antony Blinken termed the action a "gross violation of international law".

> Israel risks greater international scrutiny of its policy and practices towards the Palestinians.

Whereas what the US leaders said were indeed correct, they carried little weight simply because of Washington's previous stand on similar issues elsewhere. The US and its allies invaded Iraq in 2003 on charges that were a big suspect from the very beginning and could not obtain confirmation from the United Nations. Remaking borders by force violates a core principle of international law. Which is why the Biden administration must do more than resist Russia's aggression in Ukraine. It must stop flouting of that principle anywhere. In 2019, the US was conspicuous by being the only foreign country to recognise Israel's sovereignty of the Golan Heights, which was taken over from Syria by Israel in the 1967 War.

Palestinian Prime Minister Mohammed Ishtaye recently made an appeal for an international pressure group to compel Israel to pull out from Palestinian territories and give vitality to the two-state solution. There is mounting support for Palestinian rights. Annoyed over British backing for Israel in sustaining the "unbearable status quo", The Guardian news outlet attributes Britain's complicit in the oppression of Palestinians to diplomatic and military support together with a thriving arms trade. Although the US and the UK governments are among Israel's staunchest supporters, their publics have witnessed divisions over official policies. Some prominent British organisations demand that military exports to the Jewish state be stopped.

Review in order

A Joint Arab-Islamic Extraordinary Summit held in the Saudi Arabian city of Riyadh in November condemned the Israeli "aggression against the Palestinian people". But a powerful leader of the Muslim world, Saudi Arabia asserted its weight in scuttling a proposal that all diplomatic ties with Israel be snapped off and sanctions be applied against the Jewish state. However, that does not conceal growing mass anger in Muslim countries as well as other countries. Houthis, the Yemen-based Islamist political and military outfit, has been attacking targets within Israel and those of the latter's allies. Originating in Yemen, the Houthis have been launching attacks on Israeli and Western installations after Israeli troops stepped up attacks on Gaza. Various groups want them to ignore the United Nations "just as the Israelis do".

Too much reliance on its traditional allies since so long does not guarantee that things will remain the same forever for Israel. New power equations in the international political landscape cannot guarantee status quo in existing bilateral ties and traditional backing. Israel risks greater international scrutiny of its policy and practices towards the Palestinians. Nation-first policy precedes everything else. Israel, which has maintained its independence for 75 years, is a force to reckon with in West Asia. It has defended itself against heavy odds, as underscored by several major wars. The Holocaust, in which six million Jews were exterminated by Nazi Germany, draws much sympathy for the horrific trauma inflicted on the community during World War II.

Jews carry a history of having, for centuries, been persistently persecuted mostly in West Asia and Europe. They deserve their right to independence. But it is also time that Israel reviewed its policy on Palestine for prospects of greater peace. In a dramatic development carrying considerable meaning is the offer made on Saturday to Israel by five Arab nations to commit themselves to complete normalisation of relations with the Jewish state in exchange for agreement to an independent Palestinian state.

(Professor Kharel specialises in political communication.)

Take Steps To Save Lives On Roads



Ballav Dahal

In deficiency of collective and thoughtful interventions aimed at reducing road accidents, Nepal witnesses a considerable number of road crash deaths every year. It is saddening to mention here that the country has one of the highest road fatality rates in South Asia as a whole. Nearly 3,000 people lose their lives in road mishaps annually while thousands of others get maimed. This figure accounts only for those who die on the spot. Several from among those injured also pass away in the course of treatment. With an increase in investment in the expansion of road networks nationwide, there has been a significant rise in the number of vehicles over the years. This poses an additional challenge to the nation's poor transport management system.

Records of the Nepal Police show an awful scenario of road crashes and resulting fatalities. In fiscal year 2078-79 B.S., almost 2,900 people died in road accidents across the country. The police recorded as many as 24,000 vehicular mishaps during that period. However, the number slightly dropped to 2,368 in fiscal year 2079-80 B.S. The nation logged more than 900 road fatalities in the first five months of the current fiscal year. But many road mishaps and fatalities go unreported.

Rising fatalities

The densely-populated Kathmandu Valley also sees a lot of road accidents and deaths annually. The valley alone recorded a total of 88 casualties on the road in the first six months of the current fiscal year (2080-81 B.S.). Almost 50 per cent of about four million vehicles, including motorcycles, ply the roads within this valley. On average, eight persons lose their lives in road accidents daily. This speaks volumes about the gravity of the problem. Pedestrians, motorcyclists and cyclists are at higher risk of road mishaps.

It is needless to mention that overspeed, violation of traffic rules, recklessness on the part of drivers, mechanical problems, and bad condition of roads are major factors leading to road disasters. Traffic police officials often point out overspeed and non-compliance with traffic rules as the leading causes of road accidents. The tendency among pedestrians to cross roads haphazardly is also responsible for vehicular mishaps. Many roads even in urban areas do not have footpaths. Because of this, many pedestrians seem to have fallen into road accidents time and again. Traffic police offices are found taking initiatives frequently to raise public awareness of road accidents.

But such efforts do not appear to have been so effective in reducing the number of road disasters. Neither drivers nor pedestrians seem to be following traffic rules rigorously. So, it is necessary to enhance the capacity of the traffic police so as to increase their surveillance. What is more worrying is that drivers are sometimes found driving vehicles after having consumed alcohol or narcotics. However, traffic police units have given continuity to checking drunk driving. This step is said to have contributed considerably towards preventing many accidents. The authorities must enhance surveillance with the use of digital technology to improve road safety situation.

> Emergency rescue services should be put in place on national highways as well as other roads. Strict road safety laws are essential for taking action against those who defy such laws.

It is obvious that road safety also has a substantial economic impact. Experts say that the financial cost of road traffic injuries has an important impact on the gross national product (GNP). As per a study, which was conducted by the World Bank indicated that the financial cost of road crash injuries has risen substantially for the past one and a half decades or so. The study shows that it is now equivalent to 1.5 per cent of the GNP. This is because a considerable number of road fatality victims in the country are susceptible people such as pedestrians and those riding motorcycles and cycles. Those injured are unable to earn money and their medical expenses are very high. This situation forces them into profound poverty. Thus, road safety is a key transportation and development challenge as it impacts health, human capital and economic growth.

Although the Nepal government seems to have done something to improve road safety over the past couple of years, much remains to be done in this connection. Considering a distressing situation of road accidents, the then government had formed the National Road Safety Council (NRSC) as an inter-departmental body to ensure safer roads. This agency is led by the Ministry of Physical Infrastructure and Transport. But NRSC has not come into operation owing to a lack of laws and necessary budget. Because the proposed National Road Safety Bill could not move ahead as anticipated, the ministry some months ago drafted another bill to guide the NRSC. But the government has not tabled it in parliament. As road safety is a critical issue, the government must prioritise this and act accordingly to save lives on roads.

Rescue services

To reduce the number of road accidents, the three-tier governments need to make collaborative efforts. Emergency rescue services should be put in place on national highways as well as other roads. Strict road safety laws are essential for taking action against those who defy such laws. It is a matter of shame that there have been irregularities in the issuance of driving licenses. Chances of road accidents are very high when fake driving license holders drive vehicles. The authorities concerned must consider this issue seriously and take action against those involved in this crime.

There has been a practice of forming an investigation team immediately after any major road mishap takes place. Such panels seem to have given suggestions to the responsible government bodies to take necessary steps for ensuring road safety. But those recommendations are rarely found being implemented. The relevant authorities must pay attention towards this matter in order to prevent additional road disasters.

(The author is a former deputy executive editor of this daily.)

50 YEARS AGO

THE RISING NEPAL

January 29, 1974

Rs 60,000 Worth Of Jute Damaged By Fire In Biratnagar

Biratnagar, Jan. 28: Fire broke out last Saturday at Hanuman Jute Press at Biratnagar town panchayat ward no 11 causing damage to sixty thousand rupees worth of jute stored in the godown, reports RSS.

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READER'S MAIL

Follow Gaire's Example



I am writing this to express my happiness after reading the news story this daily published on Jan. 28 titled *"People's Front leader sets example in fruit cultivation"*. The inspiring story is about Rajendra Prasad Gaire of Syangja district, who despite being in his seventies, is actively involved in politics and fruit farming.

The highly productive life he leads is a lesson that age is no barrier to start doing something important in life. Starting his farming after buying 60 ropanis of fallow land, Gaire has earned Rs. 1 million by selling oranges this year. He has set an example for the youth aspiring to go abroad to earn money that with right mind set and hard work one can earn enough money staying with one's family.

More importantly, our lazy political leaders, who think doing only politics is a full-time job, should learn a lesson or two and involve themselves in productive work so that they be a service to the people rather than a burden.

Nikeesa Neupane Dang

TAILPIECE

A kindergarten student was having trouble putting on his boots, and asked his teacher for help. Even with her pulling and him pushing, the boots still didn't want to go on. Finally they got both boots on. She grimaced when the little boy said, "They're on the wrong feet."

Sure enough, they were. The teacher kept her cool as together they worked to get the boots back on - this time on the correct feet. The little boy then announced, "These aren't my boots." The teacher sighed and pulled the boots off.

The boy then said, "They're my brother's boots. My Mom made me wear them."

The teacher felt like crying, but she mustered up the strength to wrestle the boots back onto his feet. "Now," she said, "where are your mittens?"

The boy replied, "I stuffed them in my boots...."

UN chief calls on countries to resume funding Gaza aid agency

AP
Gaza Strip, Jan. 28

The secretary-general of the United Nations on Sunday called on countries to continue funding the main agency providing aid in Gaza after several of its employees were accused of taking part in the Hamas attack on Israel that ignited the war four months ago.

The dispute engulfing the biggest provider of vital aid to Palestinians came as U.S. officials said negotiators were closing in on a cease-fire agreement. The emerging deal would bring a two-month halt to the deadliest-ever Israeli-Palestinian violence, which has stoked instability across the Middle East.

Antonio Guterres warned that the U.N. agency for Palestinian refugees, known as UNRWA, would be forced to scale back aid to more than 2 million Palestinians as soon as February. The coastal enclave is in the grip of a severe humanitarian crisis, with a quarter of the population facing starvation.

"The abhorrent alleged acts of these staff members must have consequences," Guterres said in a statement.

"But the tens of thousands of men and women who work for UNRWA, many in some of the most dangerous situations for humanitarian workers, should not be penalized. The dire needs of the desperate populations they serve must be met," he added.

He said that of the 12 employees accused of taking part in the attack, nine had been immediately terminated, one was confirmed dead and "the identity of the two others is being clarified." He said all would be held accountable, including through criminal prosecution.



PHOTO: AP

Palestinians displaced by the Israeli air and ground offensive on the Gaza Strip walk through a makeshift tent camp in Rafah on Saturday, Jan. 27, 2024.

UNRWA has 13,000 staffers in Gaza, nearly all of them Palestinians. It provides basic services, from medical care to education, for Palestinians families who fled or were driven out of what is now Israel during the 1948 war surrounding its creation — a majority of Gaza's population. It has expanded operations during the war, running shelters housing hundreds of thousands of newly displaced people.

More than 2 million of the territory's 2.3 million people depend on it for "sheer survival," including food and shelter, UNRWA director Philippe Lazzarini said, warning this lifeline can "collapse any time now."

The United States, which is the largest donor to the agency, immediately suspended funding over the weekend, followed by several other countries, including Britain, Germany and Italy.

The Israel-Hamas war has killed more than 26,000 Palestinians, according to local health officials, destroyed vast swaths of Gaza and displaced nearly 85% of the territory's people. The Hamas attack in southern Israel killed about 1,200 people, mostly civilians, and about 250 hostages were taken.

North Korea fires cruise missiles off coast of Sea of Japan

AFP
North Korea, Jan. 28



North Korea fired several cruise missiles on Sunday, Seoul's military said, the latest in a series of tension-raising moves by the nuclear-armed state.

The launch comes just days after Pyongyang fired multiple cruise missiles toward the Yellow Sea, which it said was a first test of a new generation of strategic cruise missiles.

Pyongyang has accelerated weapons testing in the new year, including tests of what it called an "underwater nuclear weapon system" and a solid-fuelled hypersonic ballistic missile.

"Our military detected several unidentified cruise missiles fired near waters around North Korea's Sinpo area at 8:00 am (2300 GMT) today," the Joint Chiefs of Staff said in a statement.

The JCS said the launch was under analysis by South Korean and US intelligence authorities, adding it was "closely monitoring North Korea's additional movements and activities."

Unlike their ballistic counterparts, the testing of cruise missiles is not banned under current UN sanctions against Pyongyang.

Cruise missiles tend to be jet-propelled and fly at a lower altitude than more sophisticated ballistic missiles, making them harder to detect and intercept.

On Thursday, North Korea said it had carried out its first test of a new generation of strategic cruise missiles it is developing, the Pulhwasal-3-31 a day earlier.

The test was "a process of constant updating of the weapon system and a regular and obligatory activity," the state news agency KCNA said. It did not specify how many missiles were fired.

"The test-fire had no impact on the security of neighboring countries and has nothing to do with the regional situation," the agency said.

Recent months have seen a sharp deterioration in ties between the two Koreas, with both sides jettisoning key tension-reducing agreements, ramping up frontier security, and conducting live-fire drills along the border.

Earlier this month, North Korean leader Kim Jong Un declared the South his country's "principal enemy", jettisoned agencies dedicated to reunification and outreach and threatened war over "even 0.001 mm" of territorial infringement.

In Seoul, President Yoon Suk Yeol told his cabinet that should the nuclear-armed North carry out a provocation, South Korea would hit back with a response "multiple times stronger", pointing to his military's "overwhelming response capabilities".

At Pyongyang's year-end policy meetings, Kim threatened a nuclear attack on the South and called for a build-up of his country's military arsenal ahead of armed conflict he warned could "break out any time".

Finns go to polls to elect new president

AP
Helsinki, Jan. 28

Voters in Finland were electing a new president Sunday at an unprecedented time for the Nordic nation that is now a NATO member with its eastern border with Russia closed — two things almost unthinkable a few years ago.

Polls across the country opened at 9 a.m. (0700 GMT) and will close at 8 p.m. (1800 GMT).

Unlike in most European countries, the president of Finland holds executive power in formulating foreign and security policy, particularly when dealing with countries outside the European Union like the United States, Russia and China.

Some 4.5 million citizens are eligible to vote for Finland's new head of state from an array of nine candidates — six men and three women. They are picking a successor to hugely popular President Sauli Niinistö, whose second six-year term expires in March. He is not eligible for re-election.

No candidate is expected get more than 50% of the vote in Sunday's first round of voting, pushing the race into a runoff in February.

Recent polls suggest that former Prime Minister Alexander Stubb, 55, and ex-Foreign Minister Pekka Haavisto, 65, are the leading contenders.

Stubb, who represents the conservative National Coalition Party and headed the Finnish government in 2014-2015, and veteran politician Haavisto, an ex-United Nations diplomat running for the post for the third time, are each estimated to garner 23%-27% of the votes.

Finland's new head of state will start a six-year term in March in a markedly different geopolitical and security situation in Europe than did incumbent Niinistö after the 2018 election.

Abandoning decades of military non-alignment in the wake of Russia's invasion of Ukraine, Finland became NATO's 31st member in April, much to the annoyance of President Vladimir Putin of Russia, which shares a 1,340-kilometer (832-mile) border with the Nordic nation.

NATO membership, which has made Finland the Western military alliance's front-line country toward Russia, and the war raging in Ukraine a mere 1,000 kilometers (600 miles) away from Finland's border have boosted the president's status as a security policy leader.

Advance vote results will be confirmed soon after polls close and initial results from Sunday's voting are expected by around midnight (2200 GMT). The first round results will be officially confirmed on Tuesday.

The likely second round of voting between the two candidates with the most votes is set for Feb. 11.

Iran launches three satellites into space

AP
Jerusalem, Jan. 28

Iran said Sunday it successfully launched three satellites into space, the latest for a program that the West says improves Tehran's ballistic missiles.

The state-run IRNA news agency said the launch also saw the successful use of Iran's Simorgh rocket, which has had multiple failures in the past.

The launch comes as heightened tensions grip the wider Middle East over Israel's continued war on Hamas in the Gaza Strip.

While Iran has not intervened militarily in the conflict, it has faced increased pressure within its theocracy for action after a deadly Islamic State suicide bombing earlier this month and as proxy groups like Yemen's Houthi rebels conduct attacks linked to the war.

Footage released by Iranian state television showed a nighttime launch for the Simorgh rocket. An Associated Press analysis of the footage showed that it took place at the Imam Khomeini Spaceport in Iran's rural Semnan province.

There have been five failed launches in a row for the Simorgh program, another satellite-carrying rocket. The Simorgh, or "Phoenix," rocket failures have been part of a series of setbacks in recent years for Iran's civilian space program, including fatal fires and a launchpad rocket explosion that drew the attention of former U.S. President Donald Trump.



PHOTO: AP

This photo released by the Iranian Defense Ministry on Sunday, Jan. 28, 2024, claims to show a satellite carrier is launched at the Imam Khomeini Spaceport in Iran's rural Semnan province.

The Simorgh is a two-stage, liquid-fueled rocket the Iranians described as being designed to place satellites into a low Earth orbit.

However, the U.S. intelligence community's 2023 worldwide threat assessment said the development of satellite launch vehicles "shortens the timeline" for Iran to develop an intercontinental ballistic missile because it uses similar technology. That report specifically cites the Simorgh as a possible dual-use rocket.

PRISM

Baby elephant stuck in mud saved

A tiny baby elephant found itself stuck in a muddy puddle and had no way out until its family came to its rescue and saved it.

Jolandi De Klerk witnessed this moment of an elephant family coming together and working as one, while on honeymoon with her husband. Jolandi shared this heartwarming sighting and footage with LatestSightings.com.

"It was our very first drive in Addo Elephant National Park; we entered via the Mathyolweni gate, in the South. We headed straight for the main camp when we came across our first large herd of elephants.

Police rescue circus animals

Indiana: Police and sheriff's officials say they rescued circus animals including zebras and camels on Saturday when a tractor-trailer hauling them caught fire while traveling on an Indiana highway.

Traffic on northbound Interstate 69 near Marion, Ind., was blocked when the vehicle hauling the animals caught fire at 2 a.m., according to the Grant County, Ind., Sheriff's Department.

Officials said Indiana State Trooper Edward Titus and Grant County Deputy Joshua Kennedy entered the trailer and were able to rescue the animals.

(AP)

US schools use surveillance tech to catch students vaping

AP
New York, Jan 28

When Aaliyah Iglesias was caught vaping at a Texas high school, she didn't realize how much could be taken from her.

Suddenly, the rest of her high school experience was threatened: being student council president, her role as debate team captain and walking at graduation. Even her college scholarships were at risk. She was sent to the district's alternative school for 30 days and told she could have faced criminal charges.

Like thousands of other students around the country, she was caught by surveillance equipment that schools have installed to crack down on electronic cigarettes, often without informing students.

Schools nationwide have invested millions of dollars in the monitoring technology, including federal COVID-19 emergency relief money meant to help schools through the pandemic and aid students' academic recovery. Marketing materials have noted the sensors, at a cost of over $1,000 each, could help fight the virus by checking air quality.



PHOTO: AP

In this April 23, 2014 file photo, a man smokes an electronic cigarette in Chicago.

E-cigarettes have inundated middle and high schools. The devices can dispense vapor containing higher concentrations of nicotine than tobacco cigarettes. Millions of minors report vaping despite efforts to limit sales to kids by raising the legal age to 21 and ban flavored products preferred by teenagers.

Some districts pair the sensors with surveillance cameras. When activated by a vaping sensor, those cameras can capture every student leaving the bathroom.

It can surprise students that schools even have such technology. Iglesias, who graduated in May from Tyler High School in Tyler, Texas, first learned it had sensors after an administrator came into a restroom as students started vaping.

"I was in awe," Iglesias said. The administrator tried to figure out who was involved but ultimately let all the students go.

The episode that got her in trouble happened elsewhere in Texas, at Athens High School, where her debate team was competing last February. Iglesias went into a bathroom to vape. Later that day, her coach told her she had been caught.

"I decided to partake in something that I'm not proud of, but I did it," Iglesias said, adding that her senior year was a stressful time and a close relative of hers was about to come out of jail. "I had had a lot of personal stuff building up outside."

She immediately was pulled from the debate tournament and her coach told her she could face charges because she was 18. She was sent to her district's alternative school for 30 days, which was the minimum punishment for students caught vaping under Tyler schools' zero-tolerance policy.

Students found vaping also can receive a misdemeanor citation and be fined up to $100. Students found with vapes containing THC, the chemical that makes marijuana users feel high, can be arrested on felony charges. At least 90 students in Tyler have faced misdemeanor or felony charges.

The Tyler district declined to comment on the disciplinary actions, saying in a written statement that tracking of vape usage addresses a problem that is hurting children's health.

"The vape detectors have been efficient in detecting when students are vaping, allowing us to address the issue immediately," the school system said.

A leading provider, HALO Smart Sensors, sells 90% to 95% of its sensors to schools. The sensors don't have cameras or record audio but can detect increases in noise in a school bathroom and send a text alert to school officials, said Rick Cadiz, vice president of sales and marketing for IPVideo, the maker of the HALO sensors.

TODAY IN HISTORY

1907 – Charles Curtis of Kansas becomes the first Native American U.S. Senator.
1911 – Mexican Revolution: Mexicali is captured by the Mexican Liberal Party, igniting the Magonista rebellion of 1911.
1989 – Cold War: Hungary establishes diplomatic relations with South Korea, making it the first Eastern Bloc nation to do so.
1991 – Gulf War: The Battle of Khafji, the first major ground engagement of the war, as well as its deadliest, begins between Iraq and Saudi Arabia.
2014 – Rojava conflict: The Afrin Canton declares its autonomy from the Syrian Arab Republic.
2017 – A gunman opens fire at the Islamic Cultural Centre of Quebec City, killing six and wounding 19 others in a spree shooting.
2020 – COVID-19 pandemic: The Trump administration establishes the White House Coronavirus Task Force under Secretary of Health and Human Services Alex Azar.

HOUTHI ATTACKS IN THE RED SEA ARE IDLING CAR FACTORIES

AP
Washington, Jan. 28

Car factories have idled in Belgium and Germany. Spring fashion lines are delayed at a popular British department store. A Maryland company that makes hospital supplies doesn't know when to expect parts from Asia.

Attacks on ships in the Red Sea are delivering another shock to global trade, coming on top of pandemic-related logjams at ports and Russia's invasion of Ukraine.

Houthi rebels in Yemen, seeking to stop Israel's offensive against Hamas in Gaza, are attacking cargo ships plying the waters connecting Asia with Europe and the United States, forcing traffic away from the Suez Canal and around the tip of Africa. The disruption is causing delays and driving up costs — at a time when the world has yet to vanquish a resurgence of inflation.

"What's happened right now is short-term chaos, and chaos leads to increased costs," said Ryan Petersen, CEO of the supply chain management company Flexport. "Every ship that gets rerouted has 10,000 containers on it. It's a lot of emails and phone calls getting made to replan each of those container journeys."

Adding to the bedlam in global shipping is what Petersen calls a "double whammy": Passage through another crucial trade corridor — the Panama Canal — is restricted by low water levels caused by drought. And shippers are in a rush to move goods before Chinese factories shut down for the Feb. 10-17 Lunar New Year holiday.

The threat grows considerably the longer the war in Gaza drags on. Disruption to Red Sea trade lasting a year could surge goods inflation by up to 2%, Petersen says, piling on pain while the world already struggles with higher prices for groceries, rent and more. That also could mean even higher interest rates, which have weakened economies.

For now, Man & Machine in Greater Landover, Maryland, is awaiting a shipment from Taiwan and greater China. It's been one setback after another for the company, which makes washable keyboards and accessories for hospitals and other customers.

Founder and CEO Clifton Broumand usually gets a shipment of components about once a month, but the latest delivery, which departed Asia four weeks ago, is delayed. The normal route — three weeks via the Suez Canal — has been shut down by the Houthi attacks.

Rerouting to the Panama Canal didn't work either — the shipment was stymied there by the drought-related mess. Now, it might have to cross the Pacific to Los Angeles and come by truck or train to Maryland. Broumand has no idea when the products will arrive.

"It's annoying, and it's interesting. I think our customers, everybody understands. This is not like, 'Why didn't you plan this?' — who knew?" he said. "We call our customers and say, 'Hey, it's going to be delayed. This is why it is.' Nobody likes it, but it's not going to kill anybody, it's just another frustration."



PHOTO: SUJAN GURUNG/TRN

Two-wheelers parked in underground parking lot built at Sundhara of Kathmandu. This parking facility has witnessed increased demand for shoppers after Kathmandu Metropolitan City banned parking in the New Road area.

Bring CDOs under province govt: Provincial ministers

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 28

Ministers for Internal Affairs and Law of all the seven provinces have suggested Deputy Prime Minister and Minister for Home Affairs Narayan Kaji Shrestha include and specify the role of the Chief District Officer under the structure of the provincial government.

Speaking at an interaction programme organised by the Ministry of Home Affairs in the capital on Sunday, the provincial ministers suggested including and specifying the role of the CDOs in the provincial structure of the police adjustment process, which the federal government is said to be concluding soon.

For collecting necessary information and feedback for the adjustment of Nepal Police in the provincial police office, Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' has summoned a meeting of the National Coordination Council for January 31.

Before this, Home Minister Shrestha invited the internal and law ministers of the provinces for the meeting on Sunday, according to the DPM's press coordinator Kamal Giri.

The provincial ministers insisted that the CDOs should also be structurally bound to the laws of the province to coordinate the command system under Section 22 of the Thematic Committee of the Federal, Provincial and Local Level (Coordination and Inter-relation) Act 2022.

Bagmati Province's Internal Affairs and Law Minister Ganga Narayan Shrestha said that they suggested adjusting the command system as there would be a 'dual command' when the chief district officers mobilised the police even after the adjustment.

Province Minister Shrestha said that the adjustment process would not match if again the CDO of the federal government started handling the command system and mobilising the provincial police.

"If the CDO has to mobilise the police of the province, we have suggested that the CDO should also be structurally tied to the province," said Shrestha.

Narayan Prasad Bhattarai, Spokesperson for the Ministry of Home Affairs, said that there was a need to amend the Police Adjustment Act and the Nepal Police and Provincial Police Act regarding the supervision and coordination of their operations.

Likewise, it has been decided to further cooperate with the Federal Ministry of Home Affairs and the relevant ministries of the provinces to further strengthen the peace and security situation in the country, said Bhattarai.

Nepal Police and Provincial Police Work Operation Supervision, Coordination Act – 2020 and Police Staff Adjustment Act – 2020 were discussed about police adjustment in the province police.

Minister for Internal Affairs and Law Shrestha said that there was an agreement to proceed with the adjustment process according to the law.

According to the Nepal Police and Provincial Police Operation Supervision, Coordination Act-2020, the representative of the centre (federal) will be the Chief District Officer. As there will be a problem in the adjustment when the CDO is given command to operate the province police, the internal ministers have also suggested the government amend the Act to bring the CDO's role under the Provincial Police Act.

They also discussed the provision of keeping the Kathmandu Valley Police under the Central Police, which they argued was against the Constitution.

Bagmati province has suggested that the Valley Police Office should not be placed under the Centre.

Discussions were also held about the provision in the newly proposed Federal Police Act on the moral development of the police personnel adjusted in the Provincial Police.

Minister of Internal Affairs Shrestha said that there would be no hindrance in the promotion of police personnel who would be adjusted according to the Supervision Act.

Shaman distributes clothes to students

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Urlabari, Jan. 28

Shiva Shakti Baba, a popular shaman in Letang, Morang, has distributed the school's uniform to 35 poor children of Shikshya Jyoti Primary School of Letang-9.

The shaman distributed the school's uniform worth Rs. 40,000 in the presence of the ward chairperson of Letang-9, ward members and the chairperson of the School Management Committee.

Baba has started collecting money to manage clothes for the children after seeing them go to school wearing single clothes in the winter season.

He said, "I have nothing to give anybody. The majority of students in the school are from poor Dalit and indigenous communities. The clothes have been distributed for them as a small support."



PHOTO: TRN

Shiva Shakti Baba distributing school uniform to poor children of Shikshya Jyoti Primary School of Letang-9 in Morang district.

Most of the students' clothes have been torn out and they walk to school without wearing shoes, he added.

He said, "My wish is to manage at least one bag and a pair of shoes for them."

APF establishing 'Earthquake Dedicated Unit'

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 28

The Armed Police Force Nepal is all set to establish a separate unit for post-earthquake rescue operations.

Senior Superintendent of Police (SSP) Rajendra Khadka, who is also spokesperson for the Armed Police Force, said that work had started to set up a unit with specially trained personnel for rescue during the earthquake.

"We are now preparing to open a dedicated unit for earthquake disaster management", SSP Khadka said.

He said that the new unit would be under the command of the Deputy Superintendent of Police (DSP).

There are normally about 150 armed policemen in one unit of APF. But now a new unit with at least 100 skilled manpower is going to be established within the Kathmandu Valley.

During the celebration of the 23rd anniversary of the APF last week, Inspector General (IGP) Raju Aryal announced the establishment of a special unit for earthquake rescue operations.

Spokesperson Khadka said that the APF, which is engaged in border security, production of deep divers, and disaster management in Nepal, have begun preparations to establish a separate unit for earthquake relief for the first time in Nepal.

The unit will have only armed police personnel who have undergone special training on collapsed structure search and rescue (CSSR) and medical first responder (MFR). In CSSR, the skills to rescue people and cut buildings after quake are studied

The APF has a separate Disaster Management Training School (DMTS) in Kurintar, Chitwan. Since its establishment in 2011, the DMTS has been playing vital role to enhance the capacity of APF personnel to manage and response disaster that occurs in various parts of the country, said APF.

Bangladesh court grants bail to Nobel laureate Yunus

AP
Dhaka, Bangladesh, Jan. 28

An appeals court in Bangladesh on Sunday granted bail to Nobel laureate Muhammad Yunus, who had been sentenced earlier to six months in prison for violating the country's labor laws. The court also agreed to hear an appeal against his sentencing.

Yunus who pioneered the use of microcredit to help impoverished people, especially women, filed the appeal seeking bail on Sunday morning before it was granted. He was awarded the Nobel Peace Prize for his work in 2006.

The 83-year-old economist and three other officials of the telecommunications company were sentenced to six months in prison on Jan. 1, but they were immediately granted 30 days of bail to appeal the verdict and sentence.

Sunday's court decision said the bail would remain effective until a final decision is made on the appeal for the sentencing. Defense lawyer Abdullah Al Mamun said the first hearing on the appeal would be held on March 3.

The case involves Grameen Telecom, which Yunus founded as a nonprofit organization. Yunus' supporters said the case is politically motivated, a charge that the government of Prime Minister Sheikh Hasina, who was elected for a fourth consecutive term earlier this month, has denied.

In the original verdict, the judge said Yunus' company violated Bangladeshi labor laws. At least 67 Grameen Telecom workers were supposed to be made permanent employees but were not, and a "welfare fund" to support the staff in cases of emergency or special needs was never formed.

The judge also said that according to company policy 5% of Grameen's dividends were supposed to have been distributed to staff but were not.

The judge found Yunus, the chairman of the company, and the three other company directors guilty, and fined each 30,000 takas, or $260, while also sentencing each to prison. Yunus said after the original verdict that he was innocent.

"We are being punished for a crime we did not commit. It was my fate, the nation's fate. We have accepted this verdict, but will appeal this verdict and continue fighting against this sentence," he told reporters after the verdict was announced on Jan. 1.

Grameen Telecom owns 34.2% of the country's largest mobile phone company, Grameenphone, a subsidiary of Norway's telecom giant Telenor.

Yunus is known to have close connections with political elites in the West, especially in the United States, Europe and elsewhere. He faces a number of other charges involving alleged corruption and embezzlement.

Yunus' supporters say he has been targeted because of his frosty relations with Hasina.

Ukraine says corrupt officials stole $40 million meant to buy arms

AP
Kyiv, Ukraine, Jan. 28

Employees from a Ukrainian arms firm conspired with defense ministry officials to embezzle almost $40 million earmarked to buy 100,000 mortar shells for the war with Russia, Ukraine's security service reported. The SBU said late Saturday that five people have been charged, with one person detained while trying to cross the Ukrainian border. If found guilty, they face up to 12 years in prison.

The investigation comes as Kyiv attempts to clamp down on corruption in a bid to speed up its membership in the European Union and NATO. Officials from both blocs have demanded widespread anti-graft reforms before Kyiv can join them.

Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy was elected on an anti-corruption platform in 2019, long before Russia's full-scale invasion of Ukraine in February 2022. Both the president and his aides have portrayed the recent firings of top officials, notably that of Ivan Bakanov, former head of the State Security Service, in July 2022, as proof of their efforts to crack down on graft.

Security officials say that the current investigation dates back to August 2022, when officials signed a contract for artillery shells worth 1.5 billion hryvnias ($39.6 million) with arms firm Lviv Arsenal.

After receiving payment, company employees were supposed to transfer the funds to a business registered abroad, which would then deliver the ammunition to Ukraine.

However, the goods were never delivered and the money was instead sent to various accounts in Ukraine and the Balkans, investigators said.

SC issues...

the Human Rights violators from in recommendation, appointment, promotion or any career development in any constitutional or public post, transfer the complaints of human rights violations in the period of armed conflict to Commission on Investigation of Enforced Disappearances Persons and Truth and Reconciliation Commission if these commissions are operating independently and autonomously after the amendment to the relevant statues as per the decision of the Supreme Court.

While issuing the directive order expanding the constitutional mandate and powers of the National Human Rights Commission in the writ filed by Advocate Birendra Thapaliya, the Supreme Court has done a comprehensive analysis of the national, international and comparative laws as well as previous decisions of the Supreme Court.

NRNA hands...

Acting Mayor Rai expressed his happiness over the support of the mobile blood bus in Lumbini Province by the Nepalis living abroad.

Chief District Officer of Banke Shrawan Kumar Pokharel, Central Vice-President of Nepal Red Cross Society Surendra Singh Air and other local government officials were present in the programme.

In accordance with the policy of operating mobile blood bus services in all seven provinces, the NRNA had previously handed over mobile blood buses to Koshi, Madhes, Bagmati and Sudurpashchim.

US condemns ban on Venezuelan opposition leader's candidacy

AP
Caracas, Venezuela, Jan. 28

The U.S. government and nearly 30 conservative world leaders on Saturday condemned the decision of Venezuela's highest court to block the presidential candidacy of opposition leader María Corina Machado.

The Biden administration, however, remained noncommittal about reimposing economic sanctions on Venezuela, which it has threatened to do if the government of President Nicolás Maduro failed to ensure a level playing field for the country's presidential election this year.

"The United States is currently reviewing our Venezuela sanctions policy, based on this development and the recent political targeting of democratic opposition candidates and civil society," U.S. State Department spokesman Matthew Miller said in a statement.

Machado won a presidential primary held in October by the faction of the opposition backed by the U.S. She secured more than 90% of the vote despite the Venezuelan government announcing a 15-year ban on her running for office just days after she formally entered the race in June.

The former lawmaker and longtime government foe was able to participate in the primary because the election was organized by a commission independent of Venezuela's electoral authorities. Machado insisted throughout the campaign that she never received official notification of the ban and said voters, not ruling-party loyalists, were the rightful decision-makers of her candidacy.

Venezuela's Supreme Tribunal of Justice on Friday upheld the ban, which was based on alleged fraud and tax violations, and accuses Machado of seeking the economic sanctions the U.S. imposed on Venezuela.

The ruling came more than three months after Maduro and the U.S.-backed opposition reached a deal to work on basic conditions for a fair election. The two sides agreed to hold the election in the second half of 2024, invite international electoral observers, and create a process for aspiring presidential candidates to appeal their bans.

The deal led Washington to ease some economic sanctions on Venezuela's oil, gas and mining sectors.

Miller said Friday's decision from Venezuela's Supreme Tribunal of Justice "runs contrary to the commitments made by Maduro and his representatives" under the agreement signed in October on the Caribbean island of Barbados. He said the appeal process "lacked basic elements, as Machado neither received a copy of the allegations against her nor was afforded the opportunity to respond to those allegations."

Gerardo Blyde, the chief negotiator for the opposition group known as the Unitary Platform, said Saturday that the court's ruling violates the Barbados accord. He asked for backing from the international community, specifically the presidents of France, Emmanuel Macron; of Brazil, Luis Inácio Lula da Silva, and of Colombia, Gustavo Petro — all of whom have supported the negotiation process.

Blyde also urged Maduro's allies to reverse the court's decision, arguing it constitutes a "violation of due process and the right to due defense" of Machado, who was never granted an opportunity to defend herself.

But Hector Rodríguez, a governor and member of Maduro's negotiating delegation, told reporters that Venezuela's government has followed the terms of the accord and plans to hold the presidential election this year. He added that the court's decision is a thing of the past in the eyes of his delegation.

"What happened at the opposition's request for an expedited (appeal) process based on the agreement is already an adjudicated matter in Venezuela," Rodríguez said. "We are not going to have wet rain again. ... They are not going to lock us in a permanent dynamic that does not allow us to move forward."

While the opposition's candidate remains in doubt, Maduro will be seeking six more years in office. His entire decade-long presidency has been marked by political, social and economic crisis. Under his watch, millions of Venezuelans have fallen into poverty and more than 7.4 million have migrated.

Klesha selected for 23rd Bharat Rang Mahotsav



BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 28

The play 'Klesha' has been selected for the 23rd Bharat Rang Mahotsav, one of the prestigious theatre festivals in the world.

Conceived and directed by Vijaya Karki, the play 'Klesha' will be staged at the festival on February 17 and 19.

The play was initially selected for the 2022 festival, but due to the COVID-19 pandemic, the festival could not be held at that time. This time, the festival has extended another invitation.

Out of the 62 plays chosen for the festival this time, only one play from Russia, in addition to a Nepali play, has been selected internationally for the festival. Under the festival, the Nepali play 'Klesha' will be staged twice in New Delhi and Ramnagar.

According to the official website, 59 plays from India, one from Russia, and two folk plays have been selected for the festival, which will be held from February 1 to 26.

After being selected for Bharat Rang Mahotsav, the play is set to be specially staged at Mandala Theatre on February 12 and 13.

The play, which had 24 stagings in 2020, will have three special stagings in Nepal this time.

Presented by Karman Art Group, the play features Sarita Giri, Surakshya Panta, Kushal Pandey, Sudeep Khatiwada, Bijay Baral, Bikash Joshi, Rosani Karki, Swopnil Ghimire, Sandeep Shrestha, Milan Karki, Sujan Khatiwada and Ruja Raut among others.

Actress Surakshya Panta has made her theatre debut with the play 'Klesha.'

Ramayana is the main source of the drama 'Klesha,' written by Pratiksha Kattel.

The play has tried to present the story of sage Balmiki in a purely contemporary manner.

Bharat Rang Mahotsav, which is organised annually by the National School of Drama under the Natya Pragya Pratisthan of India, will be held from February 1 this year.

Earlier, Sunil Pokharel, Anup Baral, Bimal Subedi and other Nepali artists trained by NSD participated in the festival which started in 1999.

Chitwan to host Sauraha South Asian Film Festival



BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Chitwan. Jan. 28

Sauraha South Asian Film Festival will be held in Sauraha, Chitwan from February 1.

Organised by Caravan Nepal, the festival will be held at the Chitrasari Sports Ground in Ratnanagar Municipality-7.

According to president of Caravan Nepal and film director Bimal Paudel, the festival aims to foster the development of Nepali films and boost tourism in Chitwan, particularly in Sauraha.

With over 100 stalls featuring movies, tourism, and local traditional cuisine, the festival aims to attract 50,000 viewers, generating an estimated business of Rs.15 million, added Paudel.

Paudel emphasised that the five-day event will serve as a platform for comprehensive discussions and debates on initiatives at both the government and private levels, focusing on film and tourism development, to draw the government's attention to policy reforms.

Ratnanagar Municipality is the main supporter of the festival, which will host filmmakers from eight countries, facilitating opportunities for the latest artistic creations in the South Asian region.

The festival will include competitions across feature films, documentaries and short films, with awards in categories such as best film, best direction, and best writing.

Supporting organisations for the event include the Film Development Board, Nepal Tourism Board, Nepal Telecom, Bagmati Province, Ministry of Tourism and Bharatpur Metropolitan City.

The festival will highlight the discussions on the international market and tourism development of Nepali films as well as biographies of filmmakers.

Additionally, a friendly football competition between players from East Chitwan and West Chitwan will also be held during the festival, informed Kisan Pokharel, Secretary and Director of the Festival Main Ceremony Committee.

Gokarna Giri, co-coordinator of the main festival committee, highlighted the festival's objective to rejuvenate tourism in Sauraha.

Renowned artistes including Shambhujit Baskota, Raju Pariyar, Rachana Rimal, Shanti Shree Pariyar, and others, along with local talents and bands will perform in the festival, informed the organiser.

Deepak Sameep's 'Nadi Ko Rajmarga' released



BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 28

Nadi Ko Rajmarga (Highway of a River), a collection of Laghukathas (short stories) in Nepali by Deepak Sameep, was released in the capital on Saturday.

Chancellor of Nepal Academy Bhupal Rai, critic Gyanu Adhikari, writers Bhuwan Hari Sigdel, Dr. Ishwar Mani Adhikari and Sameep himself released the book.

Appreciating Sameep's writing skill in every genre, Chancellor Rai stressed a new style of book release. "We, who sit on the dais underestimate the audience by teaching them," he confessed. "Now, we must change the stereotyped format of book releasing to not underestimate them." He suggested letting the audience themselves evaluate the book."

Critic Adhikari underlined the powerful parts as well as the shortcomings of the book. "He has got the power to express much in a few words but has to follow the rule of structure either," she commented.

Dr. Ishwar Mani evaluated tiny parts of every short stories included in the book in his boisterous speech while Sigdel and Bhawani Khatiwada highlighted the prolific parts in Sameep's writing.

Sameep professed that he loved to follow the formula while writing, but not the theories. "I always thought that I had better deconstruct the theories," he said. "His stories are the clear replicas of the false time the nation is facing," the publisher has written in the blurb of the book.

A popular Ghazal writer from Pokhara, Sameep had published two books-- Bhugol Bhitra Nakorieko Desh and Akshar Ma Desh, before this book. Published by Page Turner, the book consists of 66 stories of miscellaneous contents. The 84-page book costs Rs. 270.

Brad Pitt at Rolex 24 to film scenes for Formula One movie



AP
Dayton Beach, Jan. 28

Of course Brad Pitt is at the Rolex 24 at Daytona, the most prestigious endurance race in the United States.

The actor is not at Daytona International Speedway as a fan though. He's actually on track filming scenes for his yet-to-be-titled Formula One movie, and the storyline contains an arc in which Pitt, an aging driver, has returned to sports car racing.

His presence has been a bit of a headache to many of the other drivers in the field, mainly because of the heavy security at the driver motorhome lot, where Pitt has a spot for his downtime during filming.

IndyCar driver Scott McLaughlin complained he was denied access to his motorhome because he wasn't carrying his credential for entry — an unusual rejection for an athlete clearly in uniform coming directly from the racecar.

NASCAR driver Bubba Wallace, a regular in the Daytona infield lot, said he's been bumped to an overflow lot, same for many of the top drivers in the race.

Among them? Former F1 champion Jenson Button and IndyCar driver Colton Herta, who wondered if he should ask Pitt for advice on how to make it into F1.

They've all complained that the filming scenes have kept them awake at night as shooting begins long after the track has been cleared of the actual Rolex 24 practices. A filming session requires at least six cars on track at a time.

Among them are three identically prepared Porsche 911 GT3's painted as the actual movie car. The cars are also identical to the Wright Motorsports entry that will actually race in the twice-round-the-clock event that begins Saturday.

The other cars on track are a Mercedes and a BMW that have been described as "non-descript cars looking like they are racing," as well as a 1999 Lola V8 that is the official "camera vehicle" and rumbles loud enough to sound like a stock car and keep the drivers awake.

Herta and Button both complained the filming has woken them up this week. Button had a practical view about the disruptions.

"This race is going to be super cool and the lack of sleep is the only issue, but I'm in the cheap seats," Button said. "I think we're doing OK. We've got a big race coming up and Brad Pitt is playing a part in the event."

Jerry Bruckheimer, who also produced "Days of Thunder," is producing this F1 movie. Seven-time champion Lewis Hamilton is both a producer and technical adviser, and the director is Joseph Kosinski, who directed "Top Gun: Maverick."

It is due for release in summer 2025.

HOROSCOPE

tarot.com

Aries: You're ready to go after what you desire professionally. There may be a career or a promotion that you are very interested in, and you have the internal fire to go after it with gusto.

Taurus: Strong words garner strong reactions at present. You might not always speak up when you feel slighted or worry that the conversation is heading in a direction that you don't want to go, but today.

Gemini: Inner passions are rising to the surface. Strong feelings may flow through your mind, whether they're about a recent personal endeavor or a new person in your life.

Cancer: You can speak up for other people. In particular, if you notice that someone is being talked over or ignored in a group conversation, take today to be the kind of person who gives them a platform to say what's on their heart.

Leo: Personal enthusiasm can uplift an entire group of others! Perhaps you're being actively encouraged to be the group's cheerleader, or maybe your enthusiasm about a project you're working on is naturally spreading happiness.

Virgo: Other people might be confusing you. You may have thought that you understood your friends or your lover in a deep way, but updated information or shifting attitudes could have you asking yourself if you ever knew who they really were.

Libra: Your perception is piercing. Someone in your midst could be attempting to hide something from you, not necessarily in a malicious way -- perhaps they're simply ashamed or want to positively surprise you.

Scorpio: Your ears don't deceive you, Scorpio -- they did just say that! People around you are potentially spilling all the tea regarding recent dramatic developments or unexpected events.

Sagittarius: Usual routines are being switched up. You might have a very clear idea of the foundation that you want to create for any aspect of your life, and at last, you're able to change your pattern with the support of the planets.

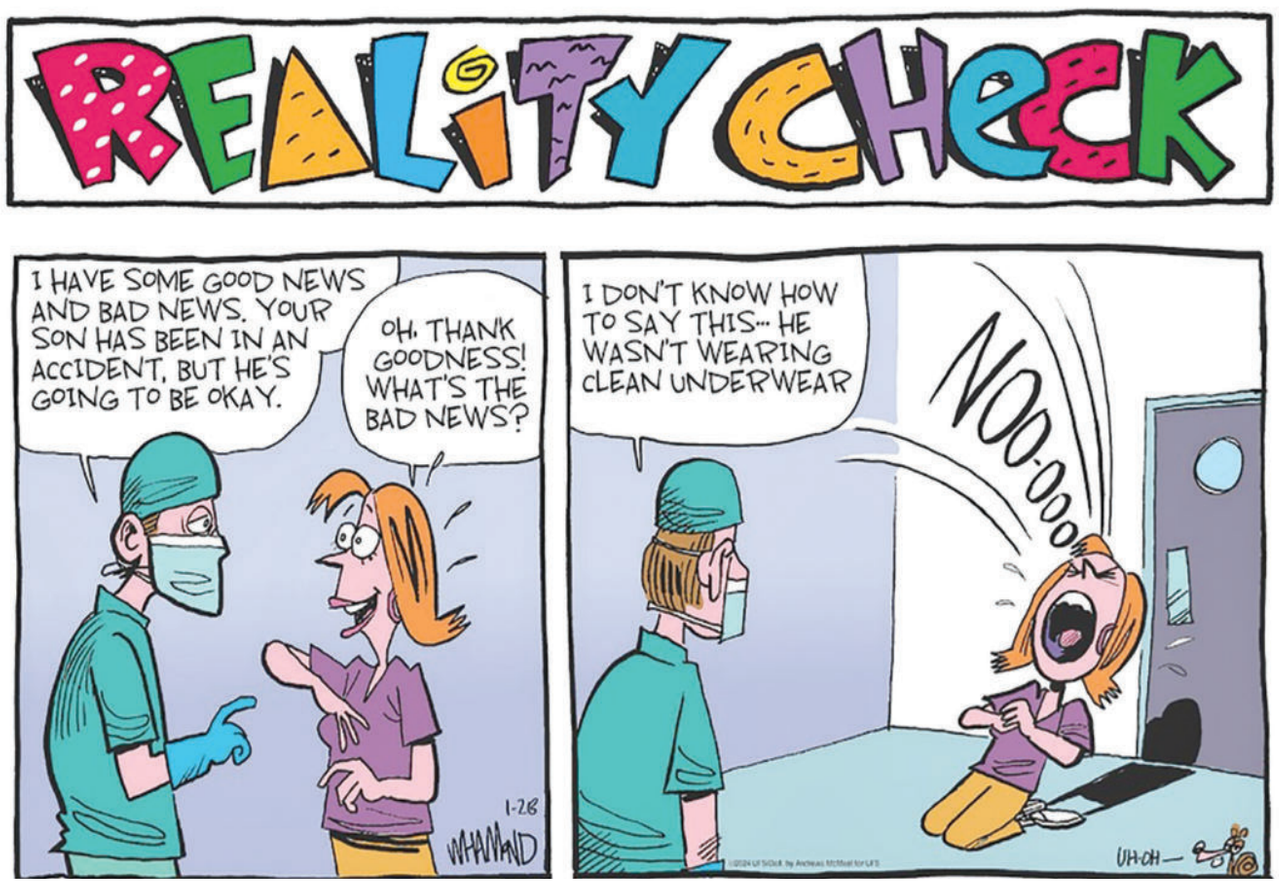
Capricorn: Your mind might be racing. With so many thoughts buzzing around your head, it could be tough to pick one direction for all that energy. It's okay if you have a tough time harnessing your current drive -- while this may feel unnatural.

Aquarius: You might be sharing your feelings in a unique way. Whether you're in a group and sharing your story, or you're simply journaling by yourself, expect to experience some emotional catharsis.

Pisces: Being the "mom" friend isn't a bad thing, Pisces. It's possible that your pals are filled with intensity today, buzzing with enthusiasm for grand adventures and multi-step projects -- and, of course.

CARTOON

gocomics.com



Madhes ends group-stage with win while Binod, Basir shine for Army

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 28

Madhes Province collected 12 points to end its group-stage campaign of the PM Cup Men's National Cricket Tournament after winning its final group match against Lumbini at Mulpani International Cricket Ground on Sunday.

Nepal Police, which has played only six matches, is in the top with 12 points followed by Bagmati, the first team to play all its group matches. Madhes is now in the third position. Nevertheless, with other teams having some more matches in hand, Bagmati and Madhes have slim chances of finishing as top four teams at the end of the group stage.

Having given to bat first, Madhes' batters did not perform at their best against Lumbini as the team was bundled out in the 42nd over at 169 runs. Captain Harishankar Sah, opener for Madhes, departed after opening his account with a single and his partner Anil Sah could only add 16 runs off 34 balls to reclaim his position as the batsman with the most runs in the tournament.

Mayan Yadav, Pawan Sarraf and Arniko Yadav added 22, 26 and 38 runs respectively followed by a 26-run-inning by Abhisekh Tiwari to take the team to 169.

Bir Magar took four wickets and Avishek Gautam claimed three to pack Madhes.

Nevertheless, Lumbini could not chase the low target as six batsmen fell victim to Pradip Paswan alone. Paswan bowled four batsmen – Birat Bhandari (1 off 15), captain Sushant Thapa (6 off 13), Dilsad Ali (22 off 37) and Krishna Karki (4 off 6) – while two others – Mrinal Gurung (21 off 50) and Nirmal Gurung (3 off 3) – were caught by fielders.

Wicketkeeper-batsman Prajjwol Thapa was Lumbini's highest scorer with 62 off 79. He was caught in the 39th over by Mayan Yadav in the over bowled by Abhishekh Tiwari. Bir Magar (5 off 6) was also caught by Yadav as Tiwari claimed the final wicket of Lumbini in the 41st over to win the match by a bare margin of nine runs.

On the other hand, Binod Bhandari and Basir Ahamad showcased quality batting at TU Cricket Ground as they partnered to take the Tribhuwan Army Club from 110/5 in the 22nd over to 279/5 at the end of the first inning against Karnali.

Dipendra Rawat took two wickets while Prakash Jaishi, Dinesh Adhikari and Diwan Pun claimed one each for Karnali.

While Bhandari was able to touch the 100-run mark and register his second century in the current edition of the tournament, Ahamad fell short of only two runs.

Bhandari stayed not out at 100 off 132 with Ahamad on 98 runs after facing only 92 deliveries.

Bhim Sharki and Kushal Malla also added 25 and 21 runs for the team respectively.

Karnali struggled in the chase as it lost six wickets by the 15th over. They were bundled out by the end of the 29th over as Army won by a wide margin of 164 runs.

Openers Rabindra Shahi, also Karnali's captain, and Nischal Rawal added 12 runs each. Wicketkeeper-batsman Arjun Gharti was bowled for a golden duck by Bibek Yadav while Aditya Shah departed after scoring only 1 run in 20 deliveries.

Himanshu Shahi was the highest scorer for Karnali with 19 runs off 22 balls followed by Diwan Pun's 18 off 14.

Bibek took a total of three wickets alongside Kushal Malla. Sompal Kami also bagged two while Shahab Alam pocketed one for Army.

Koshi and Lumbini are competing in Kirtipur and APF and Sudur Pashchim in Mulpani on Monday.



PHOTO: TRN
Tribhuwan Army Club's captain Binod Bhandari raises his bat after hitting a century, his second in the season, against Karnali at TU Cricket Ground, Kirtipur, Sunday.

NSC initiates special training for 2026 Asian Games



BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 28

The National Sports Council (NSC) has started special training camps from January 29 to prepare athletes for the 20th Asian Games and the 5th Asian Para Games taking place in Nagoya, the capital of Japan's Aichi Prefecture, in 2026.

According to the council, earlier athletes were called to prepare for the Asian Games with only a year in hand. "Now, the athletes have three years to prepare and train. This is the first time that the athletes are given more than a year to prepare," said Tanka Lal Ghising, Member-secretary at the council.

Ghising made the remarks while addressing a press conference to make the initiative public at the NSC building in Tripureshwor on Sunday.

"Nepal has been participating in the Asian Games since 1951 and has won three silver and 23 bronze medals to date. With the preparation and training, we expect Nepali athletes to win medals in double figures, including at least one gold, in 2026 alone," said Deepak Bista, head of National Team Preparation under the council.

Due to budget crunch, the council is starting special camps for five sports for the current fiscal year. "The association of five martial arts and combat sports – karate, taekwondo, boxing, wushu and judo – have referred 10 players each for the training. Among the 50 athletes, 21 are female," read a statement by the council.

"We will add more sports from the next fiscal year. We have been assured of enough budgets by the government," said Ghising.

The council has demanded Rs. 940 million for the special training camps until 2026.

"The training will be extremely beneficial for athletes as they have enough time for effective preparations," said Bista, who is also a former national taekwondo player.

There will be two coaches for each sport as referred by the respective associations and experts in the camp. The participating athletes and coaches will each be given Rs. 300 per day for diet and a kit set of Rs. 8,000.

The council will also insure the participants under health insurance alongside conducting regular health and fitness check-ups, diet and nutrition classes, motivation and sports science classes and anti-doping awareness.

As the current plan will be in effect until the end of the current fiscal year, a better plan will be implemented from the next fiscal year with more budget. "We will include 240 players in the special camp from the next fiscal year," Ghising informed.

The council also looks forward to organising as many events as possible to give more exposure to athletes. A national-level Para Games tournament is also said to be organised this year.

SNIPPETS

Nepal to host South Asian Sepaktakraw

Kathmandu (TRN): Nepal Sepaktakraw Association is hosting the 5th South Asian Sepaktakraw Championship from January 31 to February 2 between five countries. The association, which started the South Asian-level sepaktakraw championship for the first time, is organising the tournament for the third time in Nepal. According to the organisers, 90 players in total from Nepal, India, Bangladesh, Pakistan and Sri Lanka will participate in the competition for gold, silver and bronze medals in five categories – three events for men and two for women. Despite organising the tournament for the third time, Nepal has not won a single gold in the past four editions. "We have won only up to silver. However, we will win a gold this time," said the organisers.

Army oust Sankata

Lekhnath (TRN): Tribhuvan Army Club defeated defending champions Sankata FC 3-0 on Sunday to secure a place in the semi-finals of the 23rd Aaha Rara Pokhara Gold Cup. Dinesh Henjan scored twice and Gillesype Jung Karki added one goal to Army's tally at the Pokhara Stadium. Gillesype opened the scoring for Army in extra time of the first half, heading in the ball from Captain Bharat Khawas. Henjan doubled the lead with a penalty in the 49th minute, after Kuldeep Karki of Sankata handled the ball inside the box. Henjan scored again in the 76th minute, assisted by Gillesype, to make it 3-0. Army, which has played four games, is yet to win the Aaha Rara Gold Cup. They will now face the victor of the Nepal Police Club and Church Boys Beach match on January 18th.

Xavi to quit Barca

Barcelona (AFP) – Barcelona coach Xavi Hernandez said he will quit his role at the end of the season after the team's title defence was derailed in a remarkable 5-3 defeat by Villarreal on Saturday in La Liga. After Real Madrid moved two points clear of Girona at the top of the league with a late 2-1 win at Las Palmas, the pressure was firmly on Xavi's defending champions in third. "From June 30 I will not continue as Barca coach ... as a Barca fan, I think the club needs a change of dynamic," Xavi told reporters. "Thinking as a club man, I think the best thing is for me to go ... I will give my all in the four months that are left, I think we can have a good season and I hope the dynamic changes."

Sinner rallies from 2 sets down to clinch Australian Open title

AP
Melbourne, Jan. 28



Jannik Sinner rallied from two sets down to take the Australian Open final from Daniil Medvedev 3-6, 3-6, 6-4, 6-4, 6-3 on Sunday and clinch his first Grand Slam title.

The 22-year-old Sinner was playing in a major final for the first time and got there by ending Novak Djokovic's long domination of the tournament in a semifinal upset. He's the first Italian to win the Australian Open title in what could be a generational shift in tennis.

For 2021 U.S. Open champion Medvedev, the loss was his fifth in six major finals. The third-seeded Medvedev set a record with his fourth five-set match of the tournament and time on court at a major in the Open era, his 24 hours and 17 minutes surpassing Carlos Alcaraz's 23:40 at the 2022 U.S. Open.

Medvedev lost back-to-back finals here to Djokovic in 2021 and to Rafael Nadal — after holding a two-set lead — the following year. He won three five-set matches to reach the championship match this time and had two comebacks from two sets down. Sinner only dropped one set through six rounds — in a third-set tiebreaker against Djokovic — until he lost two straight to Medvedev.

It wasn't until a break in the sixth game of the fifth set that he really had a full grip on his first Grand Slam title.

Medvedev started like a man who wanted to win quickly, after playing three five-set matches just to reach his sixth Grand Slam final.

In two of those — a second-round win over Emil Ruusuvuori that finished at almost 4 in the morning, and a 4-hour, 18-minute semi-final win over No. 6 Alexander Zverev — he had to come back from two sets down. Nobody had done that on the way to an Australian Open final since Pete Sampras in 1995.

The 27-year-old Russian had spent 20 hours and 33 minutes on court through six rounds. That was almost six hours longer than Sinner took to reach the final.

Sinner didn't give Djokovic a look at a breakpoint as he ended the 10-time Australian Open champion's 33-match unbeaten streak at Melbourne Park dating to 2018.

And so the tournament equaled a Grand Slam Open era record set at the 1983 U.S. Open with a 35th match going to five sets.

Medvedev had faced either Djokovic or Rafael Nadal in all five of his previous major finals. He beat Djokovic to win the 2021 U.S. Open title but lost all the others, including the 2021 final in Australia to Djokovic and the 2022 final — after taking the first two sets — against Nadal.

Medvedev won his first six matches against Sinner, but has now lost four straight.

Joseph bowls WIndies to stunning win

AFP
Brisbane, Jan. 28



Injured pace bowler Shamar Joseph produced a stunning spell of fast bowling to lead his side to one of the greatest upsets in Test history to stun Australia by eight runs in Brisbane on Sunday.

The West Indies, who brought an understrength side to Australia for the Test series, gave debuts to four players, including Joseph, in the two Tests.

They were beaten inside three days in Adelaide last week and were expected to suffer a similar fate in the day-night Test in Brisbane.

But after bowling Australia out for 207 in the second session Sunday, the West Indies recorded their first win in Australia since they last tasted victory in Perth in 1997.

Joseph was outstanding Sunday, bowling 11.5 overs of hostile pace to finish with 7-68 in just his second Test.

Australia had resumed the day at 60-2 with Steve Smith, who carried his bat for a superb 91 not out, and Cameron Green looking comfortable against Kemar Roach and Alzarri Joseph.

Shamar Joseph, who had to retire hurt after being hit on the toe in the second innings on Saturday night, did not bowl Saturday and only came into the attack 45 minutes into the first session.

England pull off dramatic win

Debutant spinner Tom Hartley took seven wickets as England pulled off a dramatic 28-run upset win over India on day four of the opening Test on Sunday.

Chasing 231 for victory, India were bowled out for 202 in the final over of an extended third session of play in Hyderabad, as Hartley got Mohammed Siraj stumped with his left-arm spin to trigger celebrations from the England camp.

Ollie Pope stood out with his 196 to bring England bouncing back from being 190 behind at the start of their second innings to lead the five-match series 1-0.

Hartley, who got his five-wicket haul after he bowled wicketkeeper-batsman K.S. Bharat, kept coming back to return figures of 7-62 and a match tally of nine wickets.

India came into the high-profile encounter as favourites on home soil, with an unbeaten Test series record since 2012 when Alastair Cook's England beat them 2-1.

WEATHER

Monday

Sunrise at 6:52 am, Sunset at 5:42 pm

Forecast for Nepal (Monday)

Partly to generally cloudy in the hilly regions and partly cloudy to mainly fair in rest of the country. Chances of light snowfall at one or two places of the high hilly and mountainous region of the country.

Expected Temp.: 16-18 Rain Probability: 0%

Sunday's Weather Record

Stations	Max. temp. (C)	Min. temp. (C)	Rain (mm)
Dadeldhura	16.0	3.3	0.0
Dipayal	20.5	2.6	0.0
Dhangadi	14.8	7.8	0.0
Birendranagar	19.6	3.3	0.0
Nepalgunj	14.7	8.4	0.0
Jumla	16.2	-4.9	0.0
Ghorahi	18.6	5.6	0.0
Pokhara	19.3	6.0	0.0
Bhairahawa	14.5	6.6	0.0
Simara	17.8	2.5	0.0
Kathmandu	16.9	2.1	0.0
Okhaldhunga	13.9	4.8	0.0
Taplejung	15.4	3.0	0.0
Dhankuta	20.0	6.0	0.0
Biratnagar	22.5	3.0	0.0
Jomsom	8.0	-4.5	0.0*
Dharan	22.5	9.4	0.0*
Lumle	13.8	3.6	0.0*
Janakpur	21.2	5.2	0.0*
Jiri	13.6	-2.1	0.0*

NEPAL RASTRA BANK

FOREIGN EXCHANGE DEPARTMENT

EXCHANGE RATES

January 29, 2024

CURRENCY	UNIT	BUYING	SELLING
Indian Rupee	100	Rs. 160.00	Rs. 160.15

Open Market Exchange Rates
For the purpose of Nepal Rastra Bank

CURRENCY	UNIT	BUYING	SELLING
U.S. Dollar	1	Rs. 132.69	Rs. 133.29
Euro	1	Rs. 144.02	Rs. 144.67
Pound Sterling	1	Rs. 168.56	Rs. 169.32
Swiss Franc	1	Rs. 153.48	Rs. 154.17
Australian Dollar	1	Rs. 87.24	Rs. 87.64
Canadian Dollar	1	Rs. 98.64	Rs. 99.09
Singapore Dollar	1	Rs. 98.93	Rs.99.38
Japanese Yen	10	Rs. 8.95	Rs. 9.00
Chinese Yuan	1	Rs. 18.49	Rs. 18.57
Saudi Arab Riyal	1	Rs. 35.38	Rs. 35.54
Qatari Riyal	1	Rs. 36.39	Rs. 36.56
Thai Bhat	1	Rs. 3.72	Rs. 3.74
UAE Dirham	1	Rs. 36.13	Rs. 36.29
Malaysian Ringgit	1	Rs. 28.07	Rs. 28.19
South Korean Won	100	Rs. 9.92	Rs. 9.97
Swedish Kronar	1	Rs. 12.70	Rs. 12.76
Danish Kronar	1	Rs. 19.32	Rs. 19.41
Hong Kong Dollar	1	Rs. 16.98	Rs. 17.06
Kuwaiti Dinar	1	Rs. 431.36	Rs. 433.31
Bahrain Dinar	1	Rs. 351.96	Rs. 353.55

Note: Under the present system the open market exchange rates quoted by different banks may differ.

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